



NO CROWN WITHOUT BLOOD

A Bannerlord Modlist & Guide

Mount & Blade II: Bannerlord

WS v1.2.7 / BL v1.4.7

July 2026

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Installation & Setup

This section covers everything you need to set up Bannerlord with BLSE and prepare for any wave. Follow these steps once — they apply to all three waves.

Game Installation

Ensure your Bannerlord installation matches the target version before proceeding.

Warning: All mods in this guide target **WS v1.2.7 / BL v1.4.7 (8 July 2026)**. Mods marked for other versions will not work and may corrupt your saves.

On Steam

- Right-click Mount & Blade II: Bannerlord in your Steam library
- Select **Properties** > **Betas**
- From the dropdown, choose the version matching v1.4.7
- Allow Steam to download the correct version files
- Launch the game once to generate config files, then exit

On GOG / Other Platforms

- Use the platform's version management to select the v1.4.7 build
- If your platform does not support version pinning, you must ensure your installed version matches before proceeding
- Launch once, then exit

Bannerlord Software Extender (BLSE)

BLSE is the mod launcher for this modlist. It manages load order, resolves dependencies, and provides a unified mod management interface.

What BLSE Does

- Sorts mods automatically by dependency and compatibility rules
- Detects version mismatches before you launch
- Provides a clean UI for enabling, disabling, and reordering mods
- Replaces the default Bannerlord launcher entirely

Tip: BLSE is required for all waves, including Wave 0. The default game launcher does not reliably manage mod load order and will cause crashes with multiple mods. Install BLSE even if you only plan to use Wave 0.

Download & Install BLSE

Download BLSE from Nexus Mods

- Download the latest BLSE release
- Extract the archive into your Bannerlord game directory (the folder containing bin\Win64_Shipping_Client\)
- The key files are BannerlordSoftwareExtender.exe and the BLSE folder
- Launch BannerlordSoftwareExtender.exe — this replaces your normal game launch

First Launch with BLSE

- BLSE will scan your game directory and detect installed mods on first launch
- You will see the main mod management screen with a list of detected mods (empty initially for Wave 0)
- The load order panel on the right shows the current order

- BLSE's **Auto-Sort** button resolves dependencies automatically

Tip: Always launch Bannerlord through BLSE, even for Wave 0. Launching through Steam or the default launcher will bypass your mod setup.

BLSE Settings

When you first open BLSE, configure the following:

Setting	Recommended Value
Auto-Sort on Launch	Enabled — ensures load order is always correct
Check for Mod Updates	Enabled — warns you when mods have newer versions
Game Launch Arguments	Leave blank unless you need specific launch flags
Backup Saves	Enabled — creates timestamped save backups before launching

Installing Mods with BLSE

For each mod in a wave's modlist:

1. Download the mod from its Nexus Mods page
2. Extract the mod folder into `Modules\` inside your Bannerlord game directory
3. Launch BLSE — the mod will appear in the list
4. Enable the mod by checking its box
5. Use **Auto-Sort** to place it correctly in the load order

Warning: Always check the mod's installation instructions on its Nexus page. Some mods require specific subfolder placement or additional dependencies not listed here.

Wave-Specific Setup

After installing BLSE and your game, follow the **Getting Started** section of your chosen wave. Each wave has its own mod list and recommended game settings.

Choosing Your Wave

- **Wave 0 — The Exile:** You are new to Bannerlord or want a guided first campaign. Minimal mods, complete tutorial.
- **Wave 1 — The Alliance:** You have completed a campaign or are familiar with Bannerlord's basics. Enhanced experience, more mechanics.
- **Wave 2 — The Reckoning:** You are a veteran player seeking a transformed, challenging experience with major overhauls.

Danger: Do not mix mods from different waves. Each wave's mod list is tested as a complete set. Adding Wave 2 mods to a Wave 1 setup will cause conflicts and crashes.

Game Settings

Regardless of your wave, these baseline settings are recommended:

Setting	Value
Difficulty	Freebooter (medium) — adjustable per wave
Autosave Interval	15 minutes — prevents progress loss
Friendly Troops Banner Icons	Enabled — easier battle awareness

Show HUD in Combat	Enabled — shows health, ammo, orders
Graphics API	DirectX 11 — most stable for modded setups
Sound	Default — some mods add audio and rely on default settings

Tip: Graphics settings depend on your hardware. Wave 1+ graphics mods target stable 60 FPS at 1440p on an NVIDIA RTX 3080 (or equivalent). If your GPU is older or slower, reduce resolution or shadow quality — the modlist is tuned for high-end hardware.

Troubleshooting

Common issues you may encounter when setting up or playing with this modlist, and how to fix them.

Game Crashes on Startup

The most common issue with modded setups. Work through these checks in order:

BLSE Won't Launch

- Verify BLSE files are in the game root directory (not in a subfolder)
- Run BannerlordSoftwareExtender.exe as Administrator once
- Check that your antivirus has not quarantined BLSE — add an exception for the game folder
- Re-download BLSE from the official page: <https://www.nexusmods.com/mountandblade2bannerlord/mods/1>

Game Crashes Before Main Menu

- Disable all mods in BLSE and try launching with zero mods
- If the game launches without mods, a mod is the cause. Enable mods one at a time to find the culprit.
- Check that all mod dependencies are installed and enabled (see each wave's mod list for dependency requirements)
- Verify your game version matches WS v1.2.7 / BL v1.4.7

Crash During Loading Screen

- Your save may be corrupted. Try loading an earlier save or a new game.
- Verify load order in BLSE matches the wave's load-order.typ
- Clear the game's shader cache: delete %ProgramData%\Mount and Blade II Bannerlord\Shaders\

Mod-Related Issues

Mod Version Mismatch

BLSE may show a warning that a mod's version does not match your game version. This can happen with mods that have not been updated but still work.

Warning: If a mod shows a version warning but BLSE's Auto-Sort still loads it and the game launches, it is usually safe to use. However, always check the mod's Nexus page for compatibility notes.

Mods Not Detected by BLSE

- Ensure the mod folder is placed directly in Modules\ (e.g., Modules\MyMod\SubModule.xml)
- BLSE reads SubModule.xml in each mod folder. If this file is missing or misplaced, BLSE will not detect the mod.
- Restart BLSE after adding new mods — it scans on launch, not dynamically.

Two Mods Conflict

- Check `mod-conflicts.md` in this project — known conflicts are documented there
- In BLSE, try adjusting load order manually: the mod loaded **last** takes priority
- Some mods have compatibility patches on their Nexus pages — check the mod's files tab
- If no resolution, choose one mod over the other — running both will cause unpredictable behavior

Save Game Issues

Save Won't Load

- Saves made with mods A, B, C cannot be loaded if mod C is removed. Re-enable removed mods or start a new game.
- Saves from one wave cannot be used with another wave's mod set. Each wave requires a new campaign.
- If a save crashes mid-load, it may be corrupted. Use BLSE's **Backup Saves** feature (enabled in settings) to restore an earlier version.

Save Corrupted

Danger: Never save immediately after a battle or during an autosave. Wait a few seconds for the game to finish post-battle processing. Saving during heavy scripting can corrupt the save file.

- Use the backup save from BLSE if enabled
- If no backup exists, the save is likely unrecoverable. Start a new game with the backup setting enabled.

Performance Issues

Low FPS in Battles

- Reduce battle size in game options (Options > Gameplay > Battle Size)
- Lower shadow quality and particle effects
- Disable any graphics mods temporarily to isolate if a texture mod is the cause
- Verify your GPU drivers are up to date

Stuttering on Campaign Map

- Reduce sound channels in Options > Audio
- This is often CPU-related; close background applications
- Some large mods increase world processing. This is expected in Wave 2 setups.

BLSE-Specific Issues

Auto-Sort Places Mods Incorrectly

BLSE's Auto-Sort uses mod metadata to determine order. If a mod author did not declare dependencies correctly, manual sorting is needed.

- Check the wave's `load-order.typ` for the correct order
- In BLSE, drag the mod to the correct position in the load order panel
- Export your load order for future use: BLSE menu > Export Load Order

"Cannot Resolve Dependencies" Error

- A mod requires another mod that is not installed or enabled
- Check the mod's **Dependencies** field in the wave's mod list
- Install and enable the missing dependency, then re-run Auto-Sort

Getting Help

If none of the above resolves your issue:

- Check the Nexus Mods page of the mod causing issues — the Posts and Bugs tabs often have solutions
- The Bannerlord modding Discord servers are active and helpful
- BLSE's GitHub page has an Issues tracker for launcher-specific problems

Tip: When asking for help online, always mention your game version (WS v1.2.7 / BL v1.4.7), which wave you are playing, and your full mod list. This information is essential for anyone helping you.

WAVE 0

The Exile

Introduction

The rain came down in sheets the night your family died. Not the gentle spring rain that nourished your father's fields, but a hard, driving storm that drowned out the screams. You remember the thunder — or was it the heavy boots of your uncle's men on the stone stairs? Memory blurs the worst moments. What remains, sharp as a freshly-honed blade, is the face of your mother's guard, Ser Aldric, dragging you through the servant's passage as the great hall behind you filled with fire.

"Don't look back," he said. "Never look back."

You were fourteen. The youngest child of House Verdan, a minor noble house sworn to the Kingdom of Vlandia. Your father had been a just lord. Your mother, a diplomat who kept the peace between rival houses. Your elder siblings — three of them — had been warriors and scholars, each groomed for a role in the family's future. None of them survived the summit.

Your uncle Evran had called it a peace summit. He came under a banner of truce, with gifts and promises. Your father welcomed his own brother into the great hall with open arms. The poisoning started within the hour. By midnight, your family was dead and Evran's men held the keep. Ser Aldric got you out because he knew a passage your uncle didn't — an old escape tunnel dug during the last war.

You traveled for three weeks without stopping. Aldric sold his sword to buy food. He taught you how to start a fire in the rain, how to tell which villages would give shelter and which would sell you out. He taught you that survival has no honor — only outcomes.

On the border of Battania, in a nameless village that stank of sheep and desperation, Aldric's wounds caught up with him. The fever took three days. You buried him under an old oak, marked the grave with his sword driven into the earth, and walked on alone.

That was two years ago. You are sixteen now, or thereabouts — you stopped counting days after the first winter. You have learned to fight because the alternative is death. You have learned to trade because empty pockets mean empty stomachs. You have learned to lead because a lone wolf is just prey for a larger pack. You are nobody. A nameless face in a world that does not care whether you live or die.

Good. That is your advantage.

You are not here to survive. You are here to learn everything Calradia can teach you — how to fight, how to lead, how to build something from nothing. Because somewhere across these mountains, your uncle Evran still sits on your father's throne. He thinks you died in the fire. He thinks the line of Verdan ended that night.

He is wrong.

You will not go after him yet. You are not ready. You are still weak, still learning, still nobody. But every sword that falls to your blade, every soldier who swears to your banner, every coin you earn through your own cunning — these are the bricks of the foundation you are building. One day, when you are strong enough, when you have an army at your back and allies who fear your name, you will cross those mountains and remind your uncle that Verdan blood does not die so easily.

But that is another story. This is the story of how you started.

Wave 0 Objectives

Wave 0 is your training ground. Forget revenge for now. Focus on:

1. Learning the fundamentals of combat, trade, and leadership
2. Understanding how the world of Calradia works — its factions, its economy, its rules
3. Building your first warband and earning your first renown
4. Surviving long enough to reach Clan Tier 2
5. Completing a full campaign from obscurity to established mercenary

Tip: There is no rush. Wave 0 is designed for learning — take your time, experiment, make mistakes. You will start over in Wave 1 anyway. Use this wave to understand the game, not to beat it.

What Makes Wave 0 Different

Wave 0 is as close to vanilla Bannerlord as possible. The mod list is restricted to **UI and Quality of Life** improvements only — nothing that changes gameplay mechanics. This means:

1. You experience Bannerlord as the developers intended, but with a smoother interface
2. Every mechanic you learn in Wave 0 carries over to Waves 1 and 2 — mods add depth, not replacements
3. You can compare the vanilla experience to later waves and understand what each mod changes and why

Your Character

For the best roleplaying experience in this wave, create a character that fits the Exile background:

- **Culture:** Vlandia (your homeland) or Battania (where you fled). Both offer bonuses that help a new player.
- **Background:** You were raised in a noble house but have spent two years as a survivor. Choose backgrounds that reflect both privilege and hardship.
- **Starting age:** 16-18 (you were exiled at 14, and a couple of years have passed)
- **Starting skills:** Prioritize One-Handed (Aldric's training), Athletics (you walked across half a continent), and Trade (you learned to survive on nothing)

Tip: Character creation is covered in detail in the **How to Play** section. For now, just remember: you are not a hero yet. You are a refugee with a grudge and a long road ahead. Build accordingly.

How to Play

This guide covers everything you need to know for your first campaign. If you have never played Bannerlord before, start here. If you have played but want to sharpen your fundamentals, work through each section in order.

Character Creation

Your first decisions shape your entire campaign. Do not rush this.

Choosing a Culture

Your culture determines your starting location, initial bonuses, and which factions consider you kin. For the Exile backstory, two cultures make the most sense: Vlandia and Battania.

Trait	Vlandia	Battania
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Location	Western Calradia — rolling hills, coastal plains, and castle-studded heartlands	Northwest forests — dense woodlands, hidden valleys, and ancient hill forts
Bonus	20% more renown from battles — you climb the ranks faster when you fight	50% less speed penalty in forests — you move freely where others stumble
Troops	Shock cavalry and crossbowmen — hard-hitting charges and devastating ranged volleys	Archers and skirmishers — the deadliest ranged infantry in Calradia, backed by swift woodsmen
Narrative Fit	You return to your homeland as an exile — these are your people, your hills, your feud	You are an outsider earning trust among a proud, independent people who value proven skill over bloodlines

If you choose Vlandia, you start in familiar territory — the map you remember from childhood, the lords your father once dined with. But your uncle still rules here, and you must tread carefully. If you choose Battania, you are a stranger in a strange land. This makes the early game harder but aligns with the Exile’s journey of starting from nothing and earning every scrap of respect. Both choices are valid. Neither locks you out of any content later.

Background Skills

The background selection screen determines your starting skills. There is no “wrong” choice, but some synergize better with the Exile story than others.

Your character spent two years wandering, trading scraps, and fighting to survive. Favor backgrounds that grant **One-Handed** (Aldric’s combat training), **Athletics** (you walked across half a continent), **Trade** (you learned to barter or starve), **Leadership** (you had to convince people to trust a stranger), and **Tactics** (every fight you took was one you had to plan). These five skills form the core of a self-made survivor.

Avoid **Roguary**, **Engineering**, and **Steward** early. Roguary requires raiding and criminal activity — you are not a bandit. Engineering and Steward require infrastructure you do not yet have: you need a fief to design, a castle to manage. These skills will become useful in later waves but slow you down at the start.

Tip: There is no wrong choice in background selection. Bannerlord is designed so that any combination of skills can succeed. The advice above is about synergy with the Exile narrative and a smoother early game — not a requirement. If you want to play a Roguary-focused exile who turned to crime to survive, that is your story to tell.

Attribute Points

You have limited attribute points at character creation. Each attribute governs three skills, and the number of focus points you can invest in those skills is capped by the attribute’s value. Invest wisely — you cannot reset attribute points later.

Attribute	Governing Skills
Vigor (VIG)	One-Handed, Two-Handed, Polearm
Control (CTR)	Bow, Crossbow, Throwing
Endurance (END)	Riding, Athletics, Smithing
Cunning (CNG)	Scouting, Tactics, Roguary
Social (SOC)	Charm, Leadership, Trade
Intelligence (INT)	Steward, Medicine, Engineering

For your first character, a balanced spread is safer than min-maxing. Recommended minimums:

- **VIG 3** — enough to fight competently with any melee weapon you pick up
- **END 3** — you will run across battlefields and ride across Calradia; endurance keeps you alive
- **CNG 2-3** — Tactics and Scouting are essential for a party leader; you need them early
- **SOC 2-3** — Trade funds your journey, Leadership grows your warband, Charm opens doors
- **INT 2** — Steward helps with party size, Medicine saves your troops from dying of wounds
- **CTR** is optional — invest here only if you plan a ranged-focused build, such as a horse archer or crossbow captain

Warning: You cannot reset attribute points later in the game. Focus points can be shifted through respecialization at the Arena, but attribute points are permanent. A balanced spread with 2-3 in every attribute is always safer than dumping everything into one stat and discovering forty hours later that you needed something else.

Appearance and Name

The character creator is detailed. Take your time here — you will look at this character for dozens of hours.

Choose a name that fits Vlandian or Battanian naming conventions, or create your own. Vlandian names draw from medieval Frankish and Norman traditions — Aldric, Evran, Isidore, Seraphine. Battanian names echo Celtic and Gaelic roots — Brigid, Eogan, Niamh, Ruarc. Your name appears in diplomacy, battle reports, the encyclopedia, and every conversation in the game. Make it memorable. You can grow a beard later. The barber in town will handle that.

Controls and UI

Basic Controls

Bannerlord uses a combination of directional input for combat and standard keyboard shortcuts for menus. The default keybindings are well-designed and worth learning rather than remapping immediately.

Action	Key
Movement	W, A, S, D
Attack / Fire	Left Mouse Button
Block / Aim	Right Mouse Button + direction
Kick	E (tap)
Interact / Mount / Dismount	F
Inventory	I
Character Screen	C
Party Screen	P
Journal / Quests	J
Encyclopedia	N
Kingdom Screen	K
Clan Screen	L
Show Map Indicators	Hold Alt
Fast-Forward Time	3
Pause	Space
Troop Commands	F1 through F7

The encyclopedia (N) is your most powerful information tool. It contains every character, settlement, faction, and unit type in the game. Use it constantly — before accepting a quest, before entering a tournament, before attacking an enemy party. Knowledge is power, and the encyclopedia is free.

Combat Basics

Bannerlord's combat is directional. This is the defining feature of the series and what separates it from other action RPGs. Mastering it takes practice but rewards you with a combat system of unusual depth.

Attacking. Move your mouse in the direction you want to swing — left, right, up (overhead), or down (thrust) — then click the left mouse button. The direction of your swing determines its arc and the body part it targets. A quick flick produces a fast, light attack. Holding the mouse in the chosen direction builds power, increasing damage at the cost of speed and telegraphing. Learning when to commit is the core skill.

Feinting. Start a swing in one direction, then switch to another before releasing. Your opponent raises their guard to block the initial direction — you strike where they are no longer protecting. Feints work against all humanoid enemies, including lords and arena champions. They cost nothing and make the difference between winning and dying.

Blocking. Hold the right mouse button and match your attacker's weapon direction. Watch their weapon arm, not their face — the shoulder and elbow telegraph the incoming swing angle before the blade moves. Blocking is directional; holding the wrong guard gets you hit. This is why you practice on looters first.

Chamber blocking. Instead of blocking, attack into an incoming strike with a matching direction. This deflects their weapon and follows through with an immediate counterattack. High risk, devastating reward — a successful chamber block cannot be blocked or dodged. Start practicing this around hour ten, not hour one.

Kicking. Tap E while close to an enemy who is holding their block. The kick breaks their guard and staggers them for a free follow-up hit. The range is short — you must be nearly touching — and the timing is tight. Miss a kick and you give your opponent an opening.

Tip: Spend your first ten or fifteen minutes of any Bannerlord session in the Arena practice fights. The Arena uses equalized equipment and temporary knockouts instead of death, so you can experiment with every combat mechanic without consequence. Treat it like a warm-up — it will save your life on the real battlefield.

Mounted Combat

Your horse is your greatest asset and your largest target. Mounted combat works by fundamentally different rules than fighting on foot, and understanding these differences is essential to survival.

Speed determines damage. A couched lance at full gallop — lowered and held steady, not swung — can one-shot nearly any enemy in the game. This is the cavalry's most iconic tool and your best argument for investing in a good horse early. A sword swung from a stationary horse does less damage than the same sword swung on foot with a running start. Momentum is everything.

Attack from the right side of your horse. The default camera favors right-side strikes, and most enemies will be on your right if you circle clockwise around formations. Attacking from the left requires awkward camera movement and costs you precious reaction time. Train a clockwise approach pattern — ride past the enemy on their left, your right — until it becomes muscle memory.

Never stop moving. A stationary mounted fighter is an easy target. Archers will pick you off, infantry will swarm you, and another rider will couch-lance you while you sit there. Keep circling. Use your horse's speed to dictate engagement range — close in to strike, pull away before they can respond.

Horses can die. Unlike companions, your mount does not come back. Purchase a backup horse and keep it in your inventory — when your primary goes down in battle, you can mount the spare. Nothing is worse than being unhorsed in the middle of a cavalry engagement with no way to remount.

Warning: Horse death is permanent. Your mount has its own health bar, and enemies target it deliberately — especially spearmen, who deal bonus damage to cavalry. If your horse goes down in the middle of an enemy formation, you are surrounded, on foot, and in serious trouble. Always carry a spare.

Ranged Combat

Bows, crossbows, and throwing weapons each handle differently and fill distinct tactical roles. Your character's skill with each weapon type determines accuracy, damage, and handling — low skill means wide reticle bloom and sluggish aim.

Weapon Type	Characteristics
Bow	Fastest rate of fire, moderate damage per arrow, best suited for horse archery. Requires the Bow skill, which governs accuracy and draw speed. High-skill archers can fire while backpedaling effectively. Ammo: quivers of 20-30 arrows.
Crossbow	Slowest reload but highest single-shot damage. Can be pre-loaded before combat and fired instantly on engagement. Can be used on horseback without the Bow skill, though accuracy suffers while moving. Ideal for the first volley before switching to melee. Ammo: bolts in stacks of 20.
Throwing Weapons	Shortest range, massive damage, severely limited ammunition — typically 3-5 javelins or axes. Devastating against shields (axes break them) and heavy armor (javelins punch through). Best used as an opening attack before closing to melee, or to finish fleeing enemies.

Accuracy depends on your weapon skill level. At low skill, your reticle blooms wide and arrows fly unpredictably. At high skill, the reticle tightens faster and stays smaller during movement. Practice at the arena's archery range if available, or on looters before graduating to real battles. You do not need to be an expert archer to succeed — but having at least one ranged option for your party to use before the lines meet will win you fights before the swords come out.

Your First Hour

The game drops you into the world with a handful of recruits, a little gold, and no direction. Here is what to do first.

Tutorial Quest

The main quest, "Investigate Neretzes' Folly," starts immediately. Ten lords across Calradia hold pieces of information about a battle that happened before your story began.

This quest spans the entire game. It is not urgent. Treat it as an excuse to explore the map and meet faction leaders — every noble you encounter during your travels becomes a potential conversation that incidentally completes an objective. Do not chase the quest markers. You will speak to lords naturally as you fight, trade, and seek mercenary contracts. The quest will complete itself over time.

Your First Recruits

Open your party screen by pressing P. This is your warband — your family, your security, and your largest expense. Every soldier here counts.

Recruit from villages for tier 1 troops and from towns for the occasional tier 2 soldier. Hover over a settlement on the world map to see which troop types it offers. Different cultures produce different unit trees — Vlandian villages produce crossbowmen and heavy cavalry, Battanian villages produce archers and skirmishers, and so on. Recruit where the troops you want are born.

Target a party size of 10 to 15 soldiers for your first week. This is enough to handle looters comfortably without wages crushing your finances. Composition matters more than raw numbers: aim for roughly 60% shielded infantry and 40% archers. The infantry holds a line. The archers kill from behind it. A pure infantry party takes unnecessary casualties from ranged enemies you could have thinned first. A pure archer party folds the moment the enemy closes to melee range.

Tip: Wages are paid daily. Every recruit costs money whether you fight or not. A party of 20 soldiers might cost 30-50 denars per day at tier 1, and that cost triples as they promote to tier 3 and beyond. Expand gradually. Never recruit soldiers you cannot afford to feed for a week without fighting — a bad streak of empty roads will bankrupt you.

Food and Morale

Open your inventory and look at the food section. Every soldier you command eats every day. Run out of food and your army stops being an army.

Food	Morale Units	Notes
Grain	12	Cheapest bulk staple — buy in sacks, always carry at least a week's worth
Meat	8	Moderate cost, decent sustenance — common in villages with hunters
Fish	6	Cheap in coastal towns, expensive inland — buy where it is local
Cheese	5	Moderate cost, moderate value — often available in highland villages
Butter	4	Moderate cost, provides a morale boost when carried alongside other food types
Grapes / Olives	3	Local specialty prices — buy in the regions where they grow

The variety bonus is critical. Carrying three or more different food types grants a morale boost to your entire party. A bag of grain and a slab of meat will keep your soldiers alive, but add some butter and cheese and they will be happy about it. Happy soldiers fight better and are less likely to desert if things go wrong.

Danger: Zero food means starvation. Starvation leads to wounded troops, wounded troops lead to slowed movement on the world map, slowed movement means you cannot escape bandits, and bandits lead to a dead party. The cascade from “I forgot to buy grain” to “game over” can happen in under two minutes of world map travel. Check your food supply before leaving every town. Always carry a minimum of three days' worth.

Your First Fight

Find looters on the world map. They travel in small bands of five to fifteen, are the weakest enemy in the game, and exist purely for you to practice on.

When you approach a looter party, the pre-battle screen offers two options. “Send Troops” runs an autoresolve calculation — at party parity, you will usually win, and your soldiers will gain experience

without you risking a single personal swing. Use this for your very first fight to see how the system works and collect your first loot without pressure.

Your second fight should be manual. Select “Attack” and lead your soldiers into battle personally. The battlefield loads with your troops arrayed around you. Press F1 to bring up the movement command and click on the ground to position your troops, or press F1 then F3 to order a charge — your soldiers will seek out enemies and fight independently. For your first real battle, position your infantry on high ground with archers behind them and let the looters come to you. Charging downhill amplifies your soldiers’ damage. Standing in a river slows you down.

Stay with your infantry line. A lone exile charging ten looters alone will be surrounded, stunned, and beaten to death regardless of your combat skill. Bannerlord is not a solo power fantasy — you are a commander first and a fighter second. Lead from within the formation, fight alongside your soldiers, and retreat if the line breaks.

Loot everything. Weapons, armor, horses, grain — take it all. Even junk sells for a few denars at the nearest town. Prisoners can be ransomed at taverns. Every looter fight is an economic transaction as much as a military one. The gold from selling loot funds your next round of recruitment and food.

Visit a Town

Enter the nearest town and walk its streets. The town interior is a navigable environment, not a menu, and each district holds different opportunities.

The Tavern. Your most important stop. Here you will find mercenaries for hire, companions to recruit, and a tavernkeeper who sells trade rumors and information. Sit down at a table. Look at the characters wandering the room — a name with a colored background denotes a companion or notable character you can speak to and potentially recruit.

The Market. Buy and sell goods. Prices vary by town based on local production and demand. A mining town sells ore cheap and buys tools at a premium. A farming village has cheap grain but needs iron. Learning these relationships is the foundation of profitable trading. The trade screen highlights prices in green (below average), white (average), and red (above average) so you can make informed decisions at a glance.

The Arena. This is your training ground. Arena practice matches use equalized equipment — everyone fights with the same tier of weapon and armor, regardless of what you own. Knockouts are temporary, and death is disabled entirely. Spend at least twenty minutes here before you fight any real battle. The Arena also hosts tournaments, which are competitive multi-round melees with a prize. Check the prize before entering — if it is a named weapon, a noble horse, or a piece of high-tier armor, the entry fee is worth paying.

The Keep. If the town’s ruling noble is present, you will find them in the keep. This is where diplomatic conversations, quest hand-ins, and faction business happen. Visit the keep when you have business with a lord or want to ask for a mercenary contract.

Tip: Tournament prizes can be worth thousands of denars. A noble horse sells for more than most early-game trading runs earn in a week. Before entering any tournament, talk to the arena master and check the prize. If you see a named weapon like “Early Retirement” or a noble mount like a “Cossian,” register immediately — even if you lose, the experience is valuable. If you win, the prize can fund your entire early game.

Building Your Warband

Party Composition

Your warband is your instrument. How you compose it determines how you fight, what enemies you can handle, and what tactics are available to you.

Role	Guidelines
Shield Infantry (40%)	The backbone of your line. Shield infantry holds position, absorbs enemy charges, and protects your archers. Without shields, a formation crumbles under arrow fire before the melee even starts. Recruit from factions that produce heavy infantry — Vlandia for sergeants, Sturgia for axemen, the Empire for legionaries.
Archers (35%)	Your primary damage dealers. Archers force the enemy to advance into your infantry line or die standing still. Battanian Fian Champions are the best archers in the game, but every faction fields competent ranged troops. Position them on elevation behind your infantry for clear sightlines.
Cavalry (15%)	Your hammer. Cavalry flanks the enemy line, chases fleeing routers, and kills exposed archers. Vlandian knights and Khuzait lancers are top-tier, but even basic horsemen will route looters. Cavalry is expensive — both in recruitment cost and wages — so ease into it.
Horse Archers (10%)	Your harassment and skirmishing element. Horse archers circle enemy formations, forcing them to divide attention between the infantry in front and the arrows coming from the side. Khuzaites are the natural source, but the Aserai also field capable mounted archers. In Wave 0 this is optional; most early enemies do not demand this level of tactical sophistication.

The principle is simple: shields hold, archers kill, cavalry exploits. A party that follows this ratio can handle any equal-sized enemy without needing advanced tactics. As you climb the clan tiers and face larger forces, these percentages will shift — more cavalry for faster map movement, more archers for sieges where infantry bottlenecks at the walls — but the core structure holds for your entire campaign.

Companions

Named characters you recruit from taverns. Unlike regular soldiers, companions do not permanently die — they are wounded and incapacitated but always recover. This alone makes them priceless. A companion you have invested in for fifty hours does not vanish to a lucky crossbow bolt.

Assign companions to roles through the Clan screen (L), under the Roles tab. Each role uses the companion's relevant skill, and a higher skill means better performance:

- **Scout** — increases map visibility radius and track detection, letting you spot enemy parties and avoid ambushes before they happen. Governed by Scouting.
- **Surgeon** — reduces the number of troops who permanently die after battle and speeds up wound recovery. Governed by Medicine.
- **Quartermaster** — increases party size capacity and makes food last longer. Governed by Steward.
- **Engineer** — speeds up siege engine construction and repair during sieges. Governed by Engineering.

Check a companion's stats before recruiting them. The tavernkeeper can tell you who is available, and the companion's character screen shows their skill numbers. Do not hire the first companion you find — travel to a few towns, compare candidates, and choose the one whose skills align with the role you need most urgently. A companion with 80 Medicine will save more of your troops than ten extra soldiers.

Tip: Companions can lead their own parties starting at Clan Tier 2. You send them out as independent warband leaders who recruit, fight, and earn income on their own — and they cost you nothing. This is covered in detail in Wave 1, but remember: every companion you hire now is a future general. Choose wisely.

Equipment and Upgrades

Your personal equipment determines your combat effectiveness, and the upgrade priority is straightforward: weapon first, then armor, then horse, then shield. Do not buy the best item in each category immediately — upgrade progressively as your income allows.

A mid-tier one-handed sword and a decent chest armor beats a legendary blade and no body protection every time. You cannot deal damage while dead. Check the market in towns with smithies for better weapons, and towns near active war zones for discounted armor — fighting generates loot, and merchants near the front lines sell surplus from battles at lower prices.

Troops upgrade automatically. When a soldier earns enough experience in battle, an upgrade icon appears next to their name in the party screen — click it to promote them to the next tier. Higher-tier troops are dramatically better. A single tier 5 cavalry unit can rout a dozen looters without breaking a sweat. A tier 5 archer can drop enemies before they reach your line. Invest in your troops by fighting regularly — the experience they earn through combat is more valuable than the gold you spend on their wages.

Trading 101

Trading is the simplest way to earn gold early. The principle is ancient: buy where goods are cheap, sell where they are expensive. Learning the specific relationships between towns is where the money is.

Understanding Prices

Hover over any trade good in the market screen to see its base price and compare the local price against it. Green text means the good is below average price — buy here. White text means average — avoid unless you have cargo space to fill. Red text means above average — sell here.

Every town consumes and produces. A village with iron mines sells iron ore at a fraction of the price you would pay in a city. That same city, if it has a smithy, buys iron ore at a premium because local demand exceeds local supply. A fishing village on the coast has cheap fish. An inland desert town pays triple for fish because it has none. Learning these production-and-demand relationships is the entire art of trading, and every profitable route you discover makes the next one easier to predict.

Trade Rumors

Visit any tavern and speak to the tavernkeeper. Pay the small fee for trade rumors and the keeper will update your market knowledge with current prices at nearby settlements. This sounds minor but is actually one of the best investments in the early game.

Trade rumors save you travel time. Without them, you might spend a day riding to a town that looked promising from the encyclopedia, only to discover the price has shifted and the deal is gone. With rumors, you know before you leave whether the journey is worth the saddle time. The fee is trivial compared to the opportunity cost of wasted travel.

Quick Profit Routes

These five routes are reliable for starting traders and do not require region-spanning journeys through dangerous territory.

Route	Details
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Hardwood (Battania)	Buy hardwood in Seonon, where Battanian logging villages produce it cheap. Sell in Marunath or Car Banseth, where limited local wood supply drives prices up. Short route, fast turnover.
Grain (Vlandia)	Buy grain in Vlandian farming villages — the western plains are Calradia's breadbasket. Sell in Sargot or Jaculan, port cities whose populations outstrip local food production. Always a demand-side market.
Iron Ore (Vlandia)	Buy iron ore in Pravend or Ocs Hall, where local mines saturate the market. Sell to any town with a smithy — the workshop consumes ore daily and pays premium prices for resupply.
Fish (Coastal to Inland)	Buy fish in coastal towns, especially in Vlandia and the western Empire, where it is a staple commodity. Sell inland and especially in desert towns — Aserai cities pay double or triple for seafood that does not exist in the desert.
Dates (Aserai to North)	Buy dates in Aserai towns, where desert groves produce them in surplus. Sell in northern towns — Sturgia and Battania have no native date production and wealthy nobles who will pay for luxury imports. High margin, longer route, worth the trip.

Tip: Carry your trade goods on pack animals. Mules and sumpter horses are not glamorous, but they increase your carrying capacity from roughly 20 units to over 100. A single sumpter horse costs less than the profit from one full-load trading run. Buy one as soon as you can afford it — the capacity pays for itself on the first trip.

Avoiding Bandits While Trading

The world map between towns is dangerous. Looters are slow and easily outrun, but the real threats are Forest Bandits, Sea Raiders, and Mountain Bandits — fast, well-equipped, and lethal to a small trading party.

Take the long safe road, not the forest shortcut. Time is cheap. Troops are expensive. A route that adds half a day to your journey but keeps you on open plains where bandit parties are visible from a distance will save your warband from a fight you cannot win. Travel at night when bandit activity decreases and most hostile parties move slower on the world map. Keep your party size above 15 before attempting cross-region routes — bandits evaluate your strength and will chase weak parties they sense they can defeat.

Save your game before entering known danger zones such as forest passes or mountain crossings. If you see a fast-moving red party icon changing course toward you, reload and reroute. The game does not punish you for caution.

Warning: Sea Raiders patrol the northern coasts and are among the deadliest bandits in the early game. They carry throwing weapons, wear chainmail, and move faster than Forest Bandits. If you are trading along the Sturgian coast or the northern Empire, give Sea Raider icons a wide berth. Do not fight them until your party is tier 3 or higher and you have shields on every infantry unit.

Clan Progression

Your clan tier determines your party size limit, companion party limit, and eligibility for mercenary contracts and vassalage. Climbing the clan tiers is the primary measure of progress in Bannerlord.

Renown

Renown is earned by winning battles against opponents who test you. The calculation is straightforward: the harder the fight, the more renown you gain.

Fighting looters produces negligible renown. A 15-man bandit band defeated by your 15-man warband earns almost nothing — you outmatched them and the world knows it. Fighting an enemy party equal to or stronger than yours earns significant renown. Winning against the odds — being outnumbered — applies a multiplier. A 20-man lord party defeated by your 15 soldiers earns substantial renown and respect. The same lord party defeated by your 50-man army earns far less.

Tip: Fight enemies your size or slightly larger for the best renown-to-time ratio. Crushing 30 looters with a 15-man warband is a waste of time for renown purposes, though the loot and prisoner ransom may still make it worthwhile economically. Check the pre-battle screen for the estimated renown reward before committing.

Clan Tier Breakpoints

Each tier unlocks new capabilities and higher limits. Progress through them is the backbone of your campaign.

Tier	Requirements and Effects
Tier 0	0 renown. Party size 20. Starting tier for all characters.
Tier 1	50 renown. Party size 40. Unlocks mercenary contracts — you can fight for any faction as a paid soldier of fortune.
Tier 2	150 renown. Party size 60. Unlocks companion parties — your companions can lead independent warbands. Factions will offer you vassalage. This is your Wave 0 goal.
Tier 3	350 renown. Party size 80. Unlocks kingdom policies and additional political influence. This is a stretch goal for Wave 0 — reachable with consistent play.
Tier 4	900 renown. Party size 110. Unlocks a second companion party. You are now a significant force on the map.

For Wave 0, reaching Clan Tier 2 is your primary objective. At Tier 2, the entire game opens up — you can become a vassal, send companions out to build their own forces, and participate in faction politics. Tier 3 is a stretch goal for players who take to the game quickly. Anything beyond Tier 3 in Wave 0 is exceptional.

Mercenary Contracts

At Clan Tier 1, the hiring market opens. Visit any faction lord — approach them on the world map or find them in a town's keep — and ask to be hired as a mercenary. This is the safest way to earn steady income in the early game.

As a mercenary, the faction pays you wages based on your influence, which you earn by fighting their enemies. The faction partially subsidizes your troop wages — not enough to cover everything, but enough to keep a modestly-sized warband profitable while you fight. You gain access to the faction's towns for recruitment and trade, expanding your options beyond neutral settlements. And critically, you can leave the contract at any time with only a small relation penalty, freeing you to take a better offer when a different faction goes to war and starts paying more.

The mercenary loop is simple: sign with a faction at war, fight their enemies, collect influence and loot, leave when peace breaks out or a better-paying faction calls. Rinse and repeat until you have the gold, renown, and party strength to consider vassalage. You are a sword for hire. Act like one — loyalty is for lords, not mercenaries.

Saving and Difficulty

Save Management

Bannerlord offers two save modes. **Free Save** (Normal) lets you save anytime, any number of files, and reload at will. Use this for Wave 0 — you are learning, and the game should not punish experimentation with permanent consequences. **Ironman** is a single save file that overwrites itself, and character death is permanent. Consider this in Wave 2, when you know the game well enough to accept the stakes.

Tip: Save before entering towns, before starting battles, and before approaching large parties on the world map. The game autosaves, but not at a frequency that will save you from a bad decision made in the thirty seconds between the last autosave and the Sea Raider ambush. Manual saving is free — use it.

Difficulty Settings

Bannerlord's difficulty is granular. You can adjust individual sliders rather than choosing a single preset, and the right settings for Wave 0 are not the right settings for later waves.

Setting	Wave 0 Recommendation
Player Received Damage	Reduced to 50% — you are learning combat and will make mistakes. Reduced damage means you survive them and learn from them instead of watching a loading screen.
Troop Received Damage	Realistic — your troops should feel valuable. If they die easily, you learn to protect them. Reduced troop damage teaches bad habits that will get your soldiers killed in later waves.
Recruitment Difficulty	Normal — standard troop availability at villages and towns. Easy recruitment floods the market with high-tier soldiers, which makes the game trivially simple.
Map Movement Speed	Realistic — accurate world map travel speeds. Your choices about routes and encumbrance matter.
Combat AI Difficulty	Normal — enemies fight competently but not at their maximum skill ceiling. Good difficulty factors in the enemy's combat skill, blocking, and feinting.
Persuasion Success	Normal — speech checks are not guaranteed. Your Charm skill and choices matter.
Clan Member Death	Reduced — companions are investments. A companion who dies to a random arrow after fifty hours of development is not a fun learning experience. Reduce death chance so you can grow attached to your companions without constant grief.

Warning: These settings are for Wave 0 only. Wave 1 expects Realistic player damage, and Wave 2 expects maximum difficulty across the board. The ramp is intentional — you are meant to grow into the challenge. If you play Wave 0 on Realistic player damage and enjoy it, that is fine too. These are recommendations, not requirements.

Early Quests and Notables

Village Notables

Every village on the map contains named NPCs called notables — the headman, the local smith, a trader, and so on. These characters are your connection to the settlement's economy and troop pool.

Completing quests for notables increases your relation with them. Higher relation unlocks better recruits — at high relation, a village that used to offer only tier 1 peasants will produce tier 2 and occasionally tier 3 soldiers for you to recruit. Higher relation also improves trade prices in that village, giving you better margins on goods you buy and sell there. Invest time in villages whose troop trees you want to draw from. A few hours spent doing quests for a Battanian village whose archers you intend to recruit for the rest of the game pays dividends for the entire campaign.

Common Early Quests

The following quests appear frequently in villages and towns during the early game. Each one teaches a different aspect of the game and rewards you appropriately for your skill level.

Family Feud. A notable asks you to escort them to a confrontation with a rival family. When you arrive, a persuasion check resolves the dispute — no combat required. You will likely fail the first check; this is normal and teaches you how the persuasion system works. Good Charm XP, no risk of death, and the escort travel teaches you routes between settlements.

Extortion by Deserters. A group of soldiers has deserted and is extorting a village. Track them on the world map and fight them. Deserters are tougher than looters — they have military equipment and some combat experience — but their numbers are small. Easy combat, good relation reward, and the loot from dead deserters is better than bandit trash.

Escort Merchant Caravan. A merchant needs protection from one town to another. Your party escorts the caravan, which moves at your speed. Ambushes can happen along the route. This quest combines trade route learning with combat — you are essentially being paid to do what you should already be doing. Take every escort quest whose destination aligns with your travel plans.

Hunt Bandits. A notable asks you to clear a bandit hideout nearby. Hideouts are lairs that spawn hostile parties on the world map. Clearing a hideout involves a small-squad nighttime raid — you and a handful of your best soldiers enter the camp and fight room by room. Good combat practice in confined spaces, which is a skill that matters in sieges later. Renown for clearing the hideout, relation for the quest completion.

Army of Poachers. Poachers are operating near a village and the headman wants them gone. This quest introduces you to enemies who are not bandits — poachers are technically civilians, and how you handle them (combat versus persuasion) affects your reputation differently. Introduces you to the concept that not every hostile encounter is a simple “fight or flee” decision.

Tip: Accept all available quests before leaving a village, then execute them as a chain. Do the escort from Village A to Town B, stop in Town B to sell loot, then return to Village A with the quest completion and pick up the next one. Chaining quests by region keeps you in familiar territory where you know the towns, the markets, and the bandit spawns. Efficiency compounds — a smooth quest loop earns more gold and renown per hour than wandering the map looking for adventure.

Next Steps

Once you have completed a few quest loops, upgraded your troops to tier 2 and tier 3, and established a modest income through trading or mercenary work, you are ready for the **Getting Started** section. There you will set up your Wave 0 mods, configure your game, and begin a dedicated campaign with purpose and direction.

The road is long. The mountains are high. But you have taken the first step — and that is the hardest one.

Getting Started — Wave 0

This section walks you through setting up Wave 0 from scratch. You will install the mods, configure them, and start a new campaign with the Exile backstory parameters.

Mod Installation

Wave 0 uses only UI and Quality of Life mods. The list is intentionally short — you should install all of them before starting.

How to Install Wave 0 Mods

1. Download each mod from its Nexus Mods page (links in the Mod List section)
2. Extract the mod folder into your Bannerlord Modules\ directory
3. Launch BLSE — the mods will appear in the list
4. Enable each mod by checking its box
5. Press **Auto-Sort** to resolve load order

The correct load order is listed in the **Load Order** section at the end of this wave.

What Wave 0 Mods Do

All Wave 0 mods fall into the **UI/QoL** category. This means:

1. They change how information is displayed — better tooltips, sorted inventory, readable fonts
2. They add convenience features — quicker menus, keyboard shortcuts, saved configurations
3. They fix interface annoyances — slow dialogue, hidden stats, poor map readability
4. They do **not** change combat, economy, diplomacy, troops, items, or any game mechanic

You are playing vanilla Bannerlord. The mods just make the interface less frustrating.

Starting Your Campaign

Recommended Settings

Start a new campaign with these parameters:

- **Campaign Mode:** Sandbox (not the main quest) — Wave 0's story replaces the main quest for roleplaying purposes
- **Difficulty:** Freebooter (medium) — adjust individual settings as discussed in **How to Play**
- **Character Creation:** Follow the guidance in **How to Play** for a character that fits the Exile narrative
- **Starting Culture:** Vlandia or Battania (your choice)
- **Save Mode:** Normal (Free Save) — you are learning and should be able to reload mistakes

Tip: If you want to follow the Exile story exactly, choose Vlandian culture and start near Sargot. The “Exile” narrative places you on the Vlandian-Battanian border, and Sargot is the closest major city to that region.

Early Game Goals

Your objectives for the first 10-20 hours of Wave 0:

1. Reach Clan Tier 2 (150 renown)
2. Build a warband of 40-60 soldiers at Tier 3 or above
3. Accumulate 10,000-20,000 denars through trading and mercenary work
4. Own a workshop in at least one town
5. Win at least 3 tournaments
6. Marry (optional, but recommended for learning the mechanic)

Recommended Route

For the first campaign, follow this rough route to see the world and learn the mechanics.

Warning: This route is a suggestion, not a requirement. You can and should deviate based on what you find interesting. The world is dynamic — wars, bandit spawns, and prices change with every new campaign.

1. **Start near Sargot (Vlandia):** Recruit Vlandian infantry and crossbowmen. Do village quests around Sargot and Jaculan. Learn how Vlandian shock cavalry works.
2. **Travel east to Battania:** Visit Seonon and Marunath. Try Battanian archers — compare them to your crossbowmen. Learn forest terrain advantages. Experience the difference between faction troops firsthand.
3. **Continue east to the Empire:** The heart of the map. More towns, more quests, more tournaments, more trade opportunities. Zharona sells cheap horses — buy here. The Empire's central position means you interact with every faction's caravans and armies.
4. **Loop south through the Aserai desert:** Buy desert horses and dates. Sell to the north — this is a profitable trade loop even for beginners. Experience desert terrain and cavalry-heavy combat.
5. **Head north into Sturgia:** Recruit Sturgian infantry — they are the sturdiest shield wall in the game. Learn the difference between faction troops at the extreme ends of the spectrum. Sturgia's slow, heavy infantry is the opposite of Khuzait horse archers.
6. **Return west to Vlandia:** By now you should be Clan Tier 2, have a decent warband, and understand how trade and combat work. Take a mercenary contract with Vlandia or Battania and fight in a real war — this is the test of everything you have learned.

This loop exposes you to every major faction, every terrain type, and every troop archetype.

When to End Wave 0

There is no “completion” requirement for Wave 0. A good stopping point is:

1. You have reached Clan Tier 2 or 3
2. You have fought in at least one faction war
3. You understand how trade, combat, and clan mechanics work
4. You have experimented with different troop types and found your preferred playstyle
5. You are comfortable with the BLSE launcher and mod management

When you are ready, uninstall Wave 0 mods through BLSE (uncheck all mods), install Wave 1 mods, and start a new campaign. You cannot carry a Wave 0 save into Wave 1 — the mod changes are too significant.

Danger: Never load a Wave 0 save after installing Wave 1 mods. The save depends on Wave 0's mod list and will crash or corrupt if loaded with different mods. Each wave requires a fresh campaign. This is intentional — each wave is a different stage of the story and a different game experience.

Mod List — Wave 0

Wave 0 uses only **UI and Quality of Life** mods. These enhance the interface without changing any game mechanics. All mods must be compatible with BL 1.4.x / WS 1.2.x.

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Better tooltips showing exact stat values instead of vague descriptions
- Trait and perk details visible before committing to a choice
- Detailed weapon comparison when hovering over items in inventory

Requirements: Must not change any game mechanics. UI display changes only.

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Sort and filter inventory by type, value, weight
- Bulk sell/buy options for trade goods
- Companion equipment comparison in a single screen

Requirements: Must not add items, change item stats, or alter economy.

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Show troop speed modifiers on the campaign map
- Bandit hideout and quest location markers visible without hovering
- Faction borders and war status visible on the main map

Requirements: Must not reveal hidden information (e.g., enemy party locations through fog of war).

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Skip or speed up repetitive dialogue sequences
- Quick-load save without navigating through menus
- Keyboard shortcuts for common town actions (arena, tavern, market)

Requirements: Must not skip important story or quest dialogue without player input.

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Improved font rendering for high-resolution displays
- Adjustable UI text size for different screen sizes and resolutions
- Better text contrast for readability in bright environments

Requirements: Must work at common resolutions (1920x1080, 2560x1440). No font substitutions that break text layout.

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Party screen shows troop stats, upgrade paths, and equipment without navigating submenus
- Sort troops by type, tier, or wounded status
- Bulk upgrade troops with a single click

Requirements: Must not change upgrade costs, troop stats, or recruitment mechanics.

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Order of battle screen before combat — assign troops to formations
- Customizable formation presets saved between battles
- Better charge and advance commands with visual feedback

Requirements: Must not change troop AI behavior. UI layer only — formations use vanilla AI commands.

=== UI/QoL Mod Placeholder

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Named save files instead of auto-generated timestamps
- More autosave slots with configurable intervals
- Save file preview showing party composition and location

Requirements: Must not modify save file contents or enable save-scumming shortcuts.

Load Order — Wave 0

The correct load order for all Wave 0 mods, listed from top to bottom. Mods loaded first appear at the top; mods loaded last override and appear at the bottom.

Use BLSE's Auto-Sort function to resolve this automatically. If Auto-Sort places mods incorrectly, manually drag them to match this order.

Position	Mod	Notes
1.	Better Fonts & Text Scaling	Font mods load first to apply before other UI mods
2.	Better Tooltips	Depends on font mod for correct text display
3.	Map Enhancements	No dependencies — loads independently
4.	Inventory Management	No dependencies — loads independently
5.	Troop & Party Management	No dependencies — loads independently

6.	Dialogue & Menus	No dependencies — loads independently
7.	Battle Orders	No dependencies — loads independently
8.	Save Management	No dependencies — loads independently

Warning: The load order is a suggested template based on placeholder mods. When real mods are added, update this table with actual mod names and verified positions. Always run BLSE Auto-Sort first, then adjust manually if needed.

WAVE 1

The Alliance

Introduction

Five years. Five years since the rain-soaked staircase. Five years since Ser Aldric put his sword in the earth for the last time. Five years of learning, fighting, earning, surviving. And now? Now they know your name.

It happened slowly, the way these things do. A tournament in Jaculan where you unseated a minor lord's champion. A skirmish outside Ocs Hall where your thirty men held against a hundred, and someone wrote a song about it. A mercenary contract with Vlandia that turned into a second, then a third, until you were not just another sword-for-hire — you were an asset that lords competed for.

You have gold now. Not a fortune, but enough. You have soldiers — veterans who have bled beside you and stayed when others ran. You have companions who call you captain and mean it. When you ride into a town, people watch. Some with respect. Some with fear. Some with calculation.

You have learned what Ser Aldric never had time to teach you: that Calradia is not won by blades alone. It is won by marriages that bind houses together. By trade routes that make kingdoms dependent on your goodwill. By whispered promises in the right ears and loud declarations in the right halls. By knowing when to draw your sword — and when to keep it sheathed while someone else draws theirs.

Your uncle Evran still sits on your father's throne. He has grown fat and suspicious, they say. He executes vassals for imagined slights. He trusts no one. Good. Paranoia is a hungry animal — it devours its owner if fed long enough. You have been feeding it from a distance, spreading rumors through merchants who cross the mountains, letting Evran hear whispers of a young Vlandian captain with suspicious skill and no traceable past.

But whispers are not armies, and a reputation is not a crown. You have reached the limit of what one person can achieve alone. To take back what was stolen, you need allies. You need marriages that buy you legitimacy. You need trade networks that fund a war. You need lords who will follow you not for coin but because they believe your cause is theirs.

This is the story of how you stopped being a survivor and started being a threat.

Wave 1 Objectives

Wave 1 shifts from survival to ambition. Your goals:

1. Build a network of alliances through marriage, diplomacy, and trade
2. Master mid-game economics — workshops, caravans, and land ownership
3. Command armies, not warbands — learn formation tactics, siege warfare, and force composition
4. Ascend to Clan Tier 4 or higher
5. Own a fief, manage its development, and defend it against rivals
6. Transition from mercenary to vassal (or remain independent with sufficient power)

What Changes in Wave 1

Wave 1 introduces significantly more mods, spanning multiple categories:

1. **Graphics enhancements:** Better textures, lighting, environments. The world looks richer and more atmospheric.

2. **Light mechanic additions:** Expanded diplomacy options, improved AI behavior, new quest types. The game gains depth without losing its identity.
3. **Content additions:** New equipment, troops, and possibly factions. More variety in what you can field and who you can fight.
4. **Still no heavy overhauls:** Core systems remain intact. Wave 2 is for system-level changes.

Warning: You are expected to understand the basics of combat, trade, and clan management before starting Wave 1. The **How to Play** guide in Wave 0 covers these fundamentals. If you skipped it, go back and read it — Wave 1's strategy sections assume you know the basics.

Your Character, Reborn

The character you built in Wave 0 does not carry over mechanically (you start a new campaign), but narratively, you are the same person five years later:

- **Culture:** Same as your Wave 0 choice — this is your origin and it continues to matter
- **Background:** Your skills reflect five years of experience. Invest in Leadership, Charm, Trade, and Tactics more aggressively than Wave 0.
- **Relationships:** You know people now. When you meet lords in Wave 1, roleplay as if you have history with them — you have been in their world for years.
- **Starting wealth:** You are not poor. Invest your starting gold in workshops and trade routes immediately — you know how the economy works now.

Tip: Consider increasing the starting clan tier via mod settings if your chosen Wave 1 mods include such options. Starting at Clan Tier 1 or 2 reflects your character's established reputation and lets you jump into mid-game content faster.

Strategy — Wave 1

Wave 1 is where you stop reacting and start planning. This section covers mid-game strategy: economics, politics, warfare at scale, and the social game that determines who rises and who falls in Calradia.

Mid-Game Economics

By now, trading between towns should feel familiar. Wave 1 introduces the next tier of economic play: passive income. You do not want to be the person hauling grain between villages. You want the grain to make you money while you are fighting a war on the other side of the map.

Workshops

Workshops convert raw materials into finished goods. You buy a workshop in a town, assign a production type, and it generates daily income. The profit margin depends on three variables: the local price of raw inputs (the cheaper the better), the local demand for the finished product (higher prosperity towns buy more luxury goods), and the presence of competing workshops in the same town.

The single most important factor is village-bound production. Every town has two to four attached villages that supply specific raw materials. A town fed by grain villages will have cheap grain, making a Brewery highly profitable. A town fed by iron villages will have cheap crude iron, feeding a Smithy. Check the village production by hovering over each village on the campaign map before you buy a workshop — the wrong raw materials mean the workshop starves or operates at a loss.

Prosperity matters too. High-prosperity towns consume luxury goods faster: Velvet Weavery in Sanala or Ortysia can earn 400–600 denars per day, while the same workshop in a struggling frontier town

barely breaks even. However, high-prosperity workshops are more expensive to buy and riskier — if the town is besieged, prosperity crashes and so does your income.

The most reliable workshop types, in descending order:

Workshop	Ideal Location	Avoid
Brewery	Towns with 2+ grain villages (Jaculan, Pravend)	Towns that already have a Brewery
Smithy	Towns with iron villages (Epicrotea, Diathma)	High-prosperity towns with no cheap iron
Velvet Weavery	High-prosperity towns with silk villages (Ortysia, Amprela)	Frontier towns with low prosperity (below 3000)
Tannery	Towns with hide-producing villages, cheap input	Desert regions where hides are scarce
Wine Press	Towns with grape villages (Lageta, Charas)	Northern towns — grapes do not grow in Sturgia

Warning: Avoid Pottery workshops in towns that already have a Pottery shop. Workshop income is reduced by local competition — two Potteries in the same town split the market and both underperform. Before buying, check the town's current workshop list by talking to one of the shop workers.

Workshops cost 13,000–15,000 denars to purchase. Expect daily income of 100–500 denars depending on location and type. A well-placed Brewery pays for itself in roughly 30–45 days. A poorly chosen workshop might earn 30 denars a day and take over a year to break even. Think before you buy.

Caravans

Caravans are mobile trade operations led by a companion. You pay a setup fee of 15,000 denars, your companion takes 30 troops from your party, and the caravan travels the map independently, buying low and selling high.

A caravan's profitability depends almost entirely on the companion leading it. The formula is not complex: companions with high Trade skill spot better deals, companions with high Scouting skill avoid enemy parties and dangerous terrain, and companions with high Tactics skill survive if they do get caught. The ideal caravan leader has 100+ Trade and 80+ Scouting. A companion with 25 Trade and 20 Scouting will produce a slow, vulnerable caravan that earns half as much and dies twice as fast.

Caravan income is variable. A well-led caravan in peacetime earns 200–1,200 denars per day. In wartime, caravans become targets. Enemy lords with cavalry-heavy parties will hunt your caravans down. Losing a caravan costs the 15,000 denar investment plus the companion's equipment and troops — a devastating setback in the early game. If your faction is at war with two kingdoms, consider parking your caravans by disbanding and re-creating them when peace returns. The daily cost of an idle caravan is zero. The cost of a dead caravan is everything.

Warning: Low-Scouting companions get ambushed. It is that simple. If you send a companion with 30 Scouting into a zone patrolled by 100-man cavalry parties, the caravan lasts about a week. Train a companion in Scouting before sending them out, or accept that cheaper companions produce shorter-lived caravans. The 15,000 denar setup fee plus troop costs means each destroyed caravan sets you back roughly 20,000 denars.

You can also assign better troops to the caravan. When you create the caravan, the troops are drawn from your party. If you have 30 elite cavalry sitting in your garrison, transfer them to your party before creating the caravan. Better troops means the caravan survives border skirmishes with bandits and can sometimes even escape larger enemy parties.

Land Ownership – Fiefs

At Clan Tier 2 or higher, you can be granted fiefs — castles and towns — when you join a kingdom as a vassal. Fiefs are the ultimate long-term investment. They produce income, serve as a base of operations, and mark your transition from wandering mercenary to landed noble.

Fief income has three components. Tax revenue scales directly with prosperity: a 5,000-prosperity town produces roughly 500 denars per day in taxes, while a 1,500-prosperity castle might produce 150. Tariff income depends on how much buying and selling happens in the town's market — more caravans stopping means more tariffs. Garrison expenses subtract from these gains: you pay daily wages for every soldier stationed in the fief, and a full garrison (200–300 troops) can cost over 1,000 denars per day.

The net result is that a newly captured fief is a money pit. Prosperity is low because the town was just looted. Loyalty is low because the populace resents their new ruler. Construction is stalled because the town is starving. It will lose money for weeks or even months before becoming profitable. Budget for this — keep 50,000–100,000 denars in reserve before accepting a fief. If you take a town without savings, garrison wages will bankrupt you within a week.

Building projects upgrade your fief's infrastructure: walls provide siege defense, Fairgrounds boost loyalty and construction speed, Workshops inside the town generate additional income, and Granaries prevent starvation during winter or siege. Each project takes 30–60 in-game days and costs several thousand denars. Prioritize Fairgrounds first for the loyalty boost (faster construction on everything that follows), then Granary for food security, then income-generating buildings.

Tip: You can sell your workshops and caravans if you need emergency gold. Workshops sell for roughly their purchase price minus the last month's profits. Caravans can be disbanded from the Clan screen, recovering nothing — you lose the full investment. Consider workshops the safer passive income vehicle.

Kingdom Politics

Influence

Influence is the political currency of Calradia. You earn it, spend it, and hoard it. Unlike gold, which primarily solves individual problems, influence solves collective problems — it lets you shape the decisions of your entire kingdom.

The primary sources of influence:

Source	Amount	Notes
Winning battles	3–8 per battle	Scales with enemy lord rank and force size. Defeating a king grants the most.
Successful sieges	10–20	Taking a castle or town grants a significant burst. Leading the siege grants more.
High Charm	Passive daily	Charm skill generates influence passively. At 200+ Charm, you generate 2–3 per day without fighting.
Forum building	Passive daily	A Forum in your fief generates 1–2 influence per day per fief.

Council of Commons	Modifier	This policy boosts influence generation for all clans by 10–20%.
Donating prisoners	Variable	Donating captured lords or troops to allied dungeons grants influence based on prisoner value.
Tournaments	0.5–2	Winning tournaments in friendly towns grants a small influence bonus.

Spending influence is where strategy matters. Army cohesion costs 1–3 influence per day, and larger armies cost more — leading a 1,000-man army to siege a distant town might cost 80–100 influence over the campaign. Proposing policies costs 20–50 influence. Overruling the council on a decision (claiming a fief over their objection) costs 50–100 influence. Claiming a fief after a siege costs influence based on how badly you want it — the more you spend, the more likely the council votes in your favor.

The cardinal rule: never spend influence you do not have. If your influence hits zero, you cannot form armies, propose policies, or claim fiefs. In wartime, an influence-dry vassal is a spectator, not a participant.

Policies

Each kingdom has active policies that provide bonuses and penalties to every clan. Policies are voted on by the council, and you can support or oppose them depending on your position within the kingdom.

Policy	Effect	Strategic Advice
Council of Commons	+1 influence per notable in settlements you own	Support. Passive influence generation is always valuable. This is one of the best policies in the game for any vassal.
Senate	–20% influence cost for all council decisions	Support. Makes everything cheaper — army cohesion, claiming fiefs, proposing policies. Especially valuable if you lead

		armies frequently.
Feudal Inheritance	Fiefs pass to your clan on death, but -1 influence per fief you own	Oppose as a small vassal. The influence penalty hurts when you have few fiefs. Support only when you own 3+ fiefs and the penalty is outweighed by inheritance security.
Noble Retinues	+25% party size for all clans	Support. More troops means stronger armies, better sieges, and more influence from battles. Always good.
Citizenship	+0.5 loyalty in settlements, -5% tax income	Support if governing fiefs. Loyalty boosts construction speed. The tax penalty is minor

		compared to the benefit of faster building completion.
Imperial Towns	+10% tariff income, -1 loyalty in towns	Situational. Useful if your fiefs have high loyalty surplus. If loyalty is already low, this can push towns into rebellion.
Royal Guard	Ruler clan gains +30 party size, other clans -5% tax income	Oppose as a vassal. This directly benefits the ruler at your expense. The party size boost goes to someone who already has the largest army.
Sacred Majesty	+10% influence for ruler, -5% for everyone else	Oppose as a vassal. Same logic as Royal Guard — it funnels power to the ruler and weakens

		everyone else.
Bailiffs	+10% tax income, -1 loyalty	Situational. Money now at the cost of future growth. Support only if you need immediate gold and can afford the loyalty dip.
Deeds of the King	Ruler gains +20% renown, other clans -10%	Oppose. Renown determines clan tier progression. Why would you slow your own climb to speed up the ruler's?

Councils & Voting

When a decision needs to be made — declaring war, making peace, assigning a fief — the kingdom council votes. Each clan's vote is weighted by its current influence: a clan with 300 influence casts a heavier vote than a clan with 50.

Voting with the majority builds relations with everyone who also voted that way. If the ruler proposes war and six of eight clans vote yes, you earn +2 to +5 relation with each yes-voter by joining them. Voting against the majority costs relation with the winners and marks you as difficult — useful if you need to oppose a bad war, but do not make a habit of it.

Abstaining costs nothing and offends no one. If you do not care about the outcome or do not want to risk political capital, abstain. This is the correct move perhaps half the time — save your political fights for the votes that actually affect your holdings or your war plans.

Proposing your own initiatives costs influence (20–50) but lets you set the agenda. Propose policies that benefit you while your influence pool is high and your relations with other clans are strong. If you propose a policy and it loses 8-1, you have burned influence and made no friends. Read the room before proposing.

Marriage & Alliances

Marriage in Bannerlord is both a mechanic and a roleplaying tool. To marry a noble, you must first build relation with their clan above 20, then pass a series of persuasion checks with the family patriarch or matriarch. Once married, your spouse joins your clan as a companion-level character with their own skills, equipment, and combat abilities.

The strategic value of marriage lies in the relation boost. Marrying a daughter of Clan dey Meroc instantly raises your relation with every member of Clan dey Meroc by 10–20 points. In political terms, this is priceless. Clan dey Meroc now votes with you on the council, supports your claim to fiefs, and sends reinforcement parties when you call an army. One marriage can transform the internal politics of your kingdom.

Spouse skills matter too. A spouse with high Steward can manage your party's logistics. High Medicine means fewer deaths after battle. High Leadership means better morale and larger parties. Find a spouse whose skills complement your build — if you are a combat-focused character, marry a Steward or a Surgeon. If you are an economist, marry a tactician who can lead armies while you handle the books.

Children become playable clan members after enough in-game time passes (roughly 18 in-game years from birth). This is a long-term investment but central to Bannerlord's dynasty system. Your children inherit experience multipliers from their parents — two high-level parents produce children who level faster.

Tip: Marry for politics, not for stats. The relation boost with the spouse's entire clan is more valuable than one extra skill point. A spouse with 120 Steward from a clan that controls three towns is worth more than a spouse with 180 Steward from a clan with no land and no votes.

Army Composition & Tactics

In Wave 0, you won battles by having better troops. In Wave 1, you win battles by having better formations.

The Rock-Paper-Scissors of Troop Types

Every troop type has a counter. Understanding this matrix is the difference between winning with 50 casualties and winning with 200.

Troop Type	Strong Against	Weak Against
Shield Infantry	Archers, enemy infantry in prolonged melee	Heavy cavalry charges, horse archer harassment against a static shield wall
Shock Infantry / Two-Handers	Shield infantry — two-handed axes break shields and cleave through blocks	Archers and crossbowmen — no shield means every arrow finds flesh; cavalry lances — no shield to brace against
Archers	Unshielded infantry advancing over open ground, horse archers in ranged duels	Shield infantry in shield wall formation advancing steadily, cavalry flanking archer lines
Crossbowmen	Heavy armor — crossbow bolts penetrate plate; shielded infantry at medium range	Fast-moving targets like light cavalry; being overrun before they can reload between volleys
Heavy Cavalry	Archers from behind, isolated infantry scattered during a charge, routing enemies	Braceable spears in dense formations — horses stop dead

		on pike walls; dense forest that breaks formations
Horse Archers	Slow infantry in open terrain, static formations that cannot reposition fast enough	Dense forests that block maneuver; disciplined shield walls backed by crossbowmen who can punch through at range

No army of a single type survives contact with its counter. A pure-armor composition is a roleplay choice, not a tactical one. The minimum viable army for Wave 1 contains shield infantry to anchor a line, archers or crossbowmen to project ranged damage, and cavalry to exploit flanks and chase routers.

Formation Basics

Before battle, you can assign troops to formations through the pre-battle deployment screen. This is not optional — charging your entire army in one blob is how you lose high-tier troops to preventable deaths.

Assign Formation 1 (Infantry) to a shield wall on elevated ground. The high ground provides a damage bonus for ranged troops behind the infantry and makes enemy cavalry charges slower. Assign Formation 2 (Archers) behind the infantry line, also elevated if possible. Archers should have clear sightlines to the enemy's approach. Assign Formation 3 (Cavalry) to one flank, ideally hidden behind terrain — a hill, a forest, or a ridgeline. Cavalry spotted too early loses the element of surprise. Assign Formation 4 (Horse Archers) to the opposite flank for harassment and skirmishing.

During battle, the F1 commands govern behavior: F1+F1 holds position (infantry anchors), F1+F2 follows you (for repositioning cavalry), F1+F3 charges (only use when the enemy is already breaking), F1+F4 advances (infantry pushes forward while maintaining formation). F2 sets the formation's facing direction — always face toward the enemy's main advance or toward the most dangerous threat. F3 sets formation shape: Shield Wall for infantry under arrow fire, Skein for cavalry charges, Line for archers to maximize firing arcs, Circle for anti-cavalry defense. F4 toggles fire-at-will for ranged troops — turn it off when you want archers to hold volleys until the enemy is in optimal range. F6 delegates command to the AI, which is serviceable for flank formations while you micro the main line.

The Hammer and Anvil

The most fundamental battlefield tactic in Calradia, executed in three steps.

Step 1: The Anvil. Deploy your shield infantry as a solid line facing the enemy advance. Give the Hold command (F1+F1). Their job is not to kill — it is to absorb the enemy charge and lock them in place. Deploy archers behind the infantry, elevated, with fire-at-will enabled. The archers deal damage while the infantry holds.

Step 2: The Hammer. While your infantry engages, lead your cavalry in a wide arc around the enemy's flank. Stay at maximum bow range until you are past their formation. Do not cut the arc early — if the enemy sees cavalry approaching their flank, they will pivot to face it, and now you are charging into prepared spears instead of exposed backs.

Step 3: The Strike. When the enemy line is fully engaged with your infantry — you will see the formations merge into a chaotic melee — charge your cavalry into their rear. Rear attacks bypass shields entirely. They cause massive morale damage because the AI detects “attacked from behind” as a death sentence. A single cavalry charge into the rear of a committed enemy line can break 200 men in seconds. Immediately after the charge connects, issue Charge (F1+F3) to your infantry to capitalize on the rout.

Tip: Timing the hammer strike is the hardest part of this tactic. Charge too early, and the enemy rear ranks wheel around to face your cavalry with intact formations and braced spears. Charge too late, and your infantry breaks before you engage. Watch for the moment the enemy infantry transitions from advancing to swinging — that is when they are committed and cannot reposition.

Siege Tactics

Sieges are the defining battles of Wave 1. Taking or defending a castle or town is where wars are won, lost, and where you earn the fame that gets you noticed by kings. A successful siege defense against superior numbers can earn more renown than five field battles combined.

emph{Attacking.} Build your siege camp outside the walls. Construct at minimum a ram and one siege tower — the ram for the outer gate, the tower for the walls. Trebuchets provide a decisive advantage: build four trebuchets, move each to reserve the moment it is completed so enemy catapults cannot destroy it, then deploy all four simultaneously to overwhelm wall defenses. Once the walls are bombarded, lead the assault personally. Your first priority climbing the walls is enemy archers — they will shred your troops as they come up the ladders. Your second priority is the gatehouse controls to open the main gate for reinforcements.

emph{Defending.} Destroy enemy siege engines with your own catapults before they reach the walls — a single catapult crewed by a high-Engineering character can destroy a ram and a siege tower before they close the distance. Station archers on the walls with fire-at-will and infantry at the gatehouse and along the walls. If the enemy breaches the outer wall or gate, fall back to inner choke points — staircases, narrow courtyards, and keep entrances where numbers count for less. Your first priority in defense is destroying the enemy ram. A ram that reaches the gate will break it within two minutes. A ram destroyed halfway across the field buys you the entire siege duration.

Warning: Sieges take time. Building a full siege camp with trebuchets and towers takes 6–10 in-game days. During that time, an enemy relief army may arrive to break the siege. Check your diplomacy screen for nearby enemy armies before committing to a siege. If a 600-man army is two days away and your siege has three days to go, retreat. You will lose the field battle.

Companion Development

Companions in Wave 1 are not just helpers — they are officers who can lead their own parties, govern fiefs, and fill roles that let you delegate the work you no longer have time to do yourself.

Role Specialization

Each companion should specialize in exactly one role. Spreading skills across multiple roles produces mediocre performance in all of them. The five roles and their governing skills:

Role	Key Skills	Function
Scout	Scouting, Tactics	Detects enemy armies before they detect you. Higher Scouting = larger detection radius on the campaign map. A good scout sees threats two days before they arrive.
Surgeon	Medicine	Reduces deaths after battle. At 120 Medicine, roughly half of your wounded troops survive instead of dying. This compounds over a campaign — the surgeon you invest in at Clan Tier 2 saves thousands of troops by Clan Tier 5.

Quartermaster	Steward	Increases party size by 10–30 troops and improves food efficiency. A high-Steward quartermaster stretches the same food supply to feed 50 more soldiers.
Engineer	Engineering	Speeds up siege construction by 30–60%. A 200-Engineering engineer builds a trebuchet in a day instead of three. In a war of sieges, speed is the deadliest weapon.
Governor	Steward, Medicine, Engineering, Charm	Governs a fief in your absence. Steward speeds construction, Medicine boosts prosperity growth, Engineering improves wall strength, Charm raises loyalty. The governor's skills apply as modifiers to the fief's stats.

Companion Parties

At Clan Tier 2, you can create a companion-led party that operates independently. The party recruits troops from towns and villages, fights battles, raids bandit hideouts, and generates income through trade and combat loot. You pay a daily wage for the party (roughly 2–10 denars per troop, depending on tier), but a well-managed companion party typically earns more than it costs through battle loot and trading.

A companion party can be called into your army at no influence cost, which makes them your personal reinforcements. When you march to war, summon all companion parties first, then spend influence to call allied lords. Your own parties are free.

The companion's Steward skill determines the maximum party size — a 100-Steward companion leads roughly 60 troops. Leadership increases morale, which prevents desertion after losses. Tactics, Scouting, and combat skills determine how well the party survives encounters. Do not send a companion with 20 in all skills to lead a party — they will get wiped by a bandit group. Invest in companion skills before giving them a command, or accept that you are buying a temporary asset.

Tip: Companion parties are your first taste of delegation in Bannerlord. A well-managed party is a net positive — it earns money, gains renown, and provides free reinforcements. A poorly managed party is a money pit that bleeds denars, loses troops, and calls for rescue across the map. Do not create a party for a companion you have not invested in.

Faction Selection

In Wave 0, you stayed mostly in Vlandia and Battania. In Wave 1, the entire map is open. Your choice of faction determines the culture of your troops, the political environment you operate in, and the enemies you fight. Each of the six major factions has distinct strengths, weaknesses, and narrative hooks.

Faction	Strengths	Weaknesses	Narrative Fit
Vlandia	Best shock cavalry in the game, strong crossbowmen at all tiers, defensible western border with only one land approach, excellent sieges due to crossbow firepower	Slow shield infantry that struggles against fast-attacking two-hander troops, poor horse archers, heavy reliance on cavalry for damage means forest battles are difficult	Your homeland. Your uncle rules

			here. Joining Vlandia as a vassal puts you in direct proximity to the man who stole your birthright — and the lords you would need to turn against him.
Battania	Deadliest archers in the game — Fian Champions are the strongest ranged unit period, forest mobility bonus lets you outmaneuver any army in woodland terrain, strong individual champions for tournament play	Weak cavalry forces with no heavy cavalry option, surrounded on all sides by aggressive factions, poor siege performance without cavalry to break enemy formations on walls	The people who sheltered you when you had nothing. Returning as a proven captain lets you repay that debt — or

			reclaim it. Battanian lords respect results over bloodlines, making them natural allies for an exile.
Empire	Most balanced roster — good at everything, master of none, central position on the map means access to all trade routes, civil war split into three factions gives you choice of which emperor to back	No standout troop type — Battanian archers, Vlandian cavalry, and Sturgian infantry all outclass their Imperial counterparts in their specialty, surrounded by four aggressive kingdoms on every border	The Empire is Calradia's center of gravity. Meddling in imperial politics puts you at the table where the fate of the continent is decided. Playing kingmaker between the three claimants is a valid path.

Sturgia	Best shield infantry — Druzhinnik Champions hold a line like no other troop, strong in sieges both attacking and defending due to infantry quality, rugged snow terrain slows enemy cavalry	Slowest army on the campaign map — heavy infantry and long supply lines, poor archers at all tiers, vulnerable to horse archer harassment that infantry cannot catch	Sturgia respects strength above all. You earn your place through combat, not politics. For an exile who built their reputation on battlefields, Sturgian lords recognize a kindred spirit — someone who rose through blood and steel.
Khuzait	Best horse archers — Khuzait Khan's Guards dominate open-field battles, fastest campaign map movement speed, excellent raiding capability to harass enemy supply lines	Weak infantry across every tier, poor in sieges where cavalry cannot maneuver, low armor on most troops means archer-heavy enemies inflict disproportionate casualties	The Khuzait are outsiders to the Calradian establishment much like you. They value mobility,

			self-reliance, and results over tradition. An alliance with the Khuzait gives you the fastest path to military dominance and the loosest cultural expectation
Aserai	Strong versatile cavalry with both melee and ranged options, excellent trade routes with desert protection, defensible homeland with chokepoints and minimal borders, strong economy for long-term development	Weak early-game infantry that improves only at higher tiers, geographically isolated — takes time to march anywhere, desert terrain drains speed if you lack Riding skill	The Aserai homeland is a safe base to build power before marching north. If your long-term plan is to return to Vlandia with an army

			behind you, building your fortune in the desert gives you distance, safety, and the economic foundation to fund a campaign across the continent.
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Mechanics — Wave 1

This section covers individual game systems in depth. Each mechanic is explained with its underlying rules, optimal strategies, and how Wave 1 mods may affect it.

Smithing Deep Dive

Smithing is the most profitable skill in Bannerlord when done correctly. It is also the most misunderstood. Many players ignore smithing entirely, dismissing it as a side activity — those players are leaving millions of denars on the table.

How Smithing Works

You forge weapons from raw materials at any town’s smithy. Stamina, displayed as a smithing pool of roughly 100 units, governs how much you can smith before needing to rest. Stamina recovers by waiting in town — roughly 5–6 units per hour, meaning full recovery takes about a day of idle time. This is the game’s built-in brake on smithing, but it can be bypassed by using companions as additional smiths, each with their own stamina pool.

Smithing XP is earned by forging. The higher the difficulty rating of the weapon you forge, the more XP you gain. Smelting weapons also grants a small amount of XP, but forging is the primary source. Weapon parts unlock randomly when you smelt weapons of the same type: smelting a two-handed sword has a chance to unlock a new two-handed sword part. The more valuable the weapon you smelt, the higher the chance of unlocking a new part.

Refining converts materials up the quality ladder: crude iron becomes wrought iron, wrought iron becomes iron, iron becomes steel, steel becomes fine steel, and fine steel becomes Thamaskene steel. Refining provides no XP — it is material conversion only, useful for turning surplus low-quality materials into high-quality materials for better crafting.

The Profit Loop

The smithing economy in Bannerlord functions on a simple principle: raw material cost is disconnected from finished weapon value. A Pugio dagger costs approximately 200 denars and smelts into materials worth 1,500–2,000 denars when crafted into a two-handed sword. This is not an exploit — it is the intended design of an economic system that values craftsmanship over raw materials.

The profit loop has four steps:

1. **Step 1: Acquire cheap weapons.** Pugios (sold by Imperial towns, roughly 200 denars each) are the most efficient conversion in the game. Tribesman Throwing Daggers and Wooden Hammers are also cost-effective. Buy every Pugio you see in every town you visit — you will never find enough of them.
2. **Step 2: Smelt for materials.** Pugios smelt into fine steel, steel, iron, and wrought iron. A single Pugio typically yields 1 fine steel, 1 steel, 1 iron, and 1 wrought iron. The combined material value is roughly 10x the purchase cost of the dagger.
3. **Step 3: Craft two-handed swords.** Two-handed swords have the highest sale value per material cost of any weapon type. Use the highest-tier parts you have unlocked — specifically, look for Tier 5 blades, Tier 5 guards, and Tier 5 grips. Each tier jump roughly doubles the weapon's sale price.
4. **Step 4: Sell.** A crafted two-handed sword with Tier 5 parts sells for 10,000–60,000 denars depending on blade length, damage, and handle style. The profit margin is typically 10x to 50x the material cost. Repeat until towns run out of money.

Tip: Pugios are the most efficient material-to-value conversion in the game. A 200-denar Pugio, smelted and re-crafted into a two-handed sword, produces roughly 10,000–30,000 denars. No other economic activity in Bannerlord approaches this return on investment. If your build includes any smithing at all, prioritize Pugio acquisition on every town visit.

Part Unlocking Strategy

In the early game, smelt every looted weapon instead of selling it. The denars you would earn from selling a looted sword are trivial compared to the value of unlocking new parts. Focus exclusively on two-handed swords — they are the most profitable weapon type and have the most parts to unlock. Forge the highest-difficulty two-handed sword your stamina allows, as often as your stamina allows. Difficulty rating determines XP gain, and XP gain determines how fast you unlock new parts.

Use companions as additional smiths. Each companion has their own stamina pool and their own smithing skill progression. Assign one companion to smelting (they do not need high smithing skill to smelt efficiently) and another to refining (material conversion). Your main character does the forging — this concentrates XP on one character and maximizes unlock rates.

Do not refine for XP. Refining provides zero experience — it is strictly material conversion. Forge weapons for XP, smelt unwanted weapons for parts and materials, refine only when you need higher-quality materials and have surplus low-quality materials to convert.

Crafting for Personal Use

Not every crafted weapon is for sale. Some you will use personally. The right crafted weapon can carry you through an entire campaign.

Weapon Type	Best Use Case
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Two-Handed Sword	Versatile generalist — good balance of damage, attack speed, and reach. Effective in field battles, tournaments, and siege breaches. The default choice for most builds.
Two-Handed Axe	Shield-breaking specialist — each swing damages multiple enemies in a cleave arc. Devastates shield walls and tight infantry formations. Slow swing speed — vulnerable to fast one-handed attackers.
Polearm / Glaive	Mounted combat king — long reach lets you strike infantry from horseback without entering their weapon range. Devastating charge damage. Awkward in tight spaces and sieges.
One-Handed Sword	Siege and civic combat — used with a shield for survival in arrow-heavy environments. Lower damage than two-handers but superior survivability. The practical choice for siege assaults.
Javelins	Highest-tier javelins one-shot any unit in the game, including armored cavalry and lords. Limited ammo (typically 3–5) makes them a specialist weapon. Craft and carry for priority targets — enemy commanders, elite cavalry, and siege defenders manning wall catapults.

Warning: Smithing orders from nobles appear at towns with smithies. Check the order details before accepting — some nobles request weapons that require parts or materials you do not have. Failing an order costs relation with the noble and their clan. If the order calls for a Tier 5 part you have not unlocked, decline it. The relation loss from declining is zero.

Trade Routes

Wave 0 covered basic buy-low-sell-high. Wave 1 is about market manipulation — understanding why prices move and exploiting those movements across entire trade loops.

Supply & Demand Mechanics

Every town maintains a pool of each trade good. The pool is affected by five forces. Village production: attached villages produce raw goods (grain, iron, clay, hardwood) and deliver them to the town. Caravan activity: visiting caravans bring goods from other regions, which lowers prices for imports and raises demand for exports. Workshop production: workshops consume raw materials (a Brewery consumes grain, a Smithy consumes iron) and produce finished goods, which lowers prices for finished products and raises prices for raw inputs. Prosperity: higher prosperity increases consumption of all goods — a 6,000-prosperity town consumes food and luxuries much faster than a 2,000-prosperity town. Recent events: a siege starves a town, rockets food prices to 3–5x normal, and crashes prosperity — creating a buy opportunity if you have food to sell and a sell opportunity once the siege lifts and prices normalize.

Understanding these forces lets you predict price movements instead of reacting to them. If you know a town has been under siege for three days, you know food prices there are astronomical. If you know a war just ended between two kingdoms, you know trade routes between them are about to reopen and prices will converge.

Profitable Deep Routes

The most profitable trade is not between adjacent towns — it is across the map, where regional price differences are largest.

The Silver Route — a six-stop cycle from Vlandia to Aserai lands and back through Sturgia:

1. Buy silver and jewelry in Vlandian towns (Pravend, Ocs Hall). Silver is common in Vlandia but rare in the desert.

2. Travel south through the mountain pass and sell in Aserai towns (Sanala, Quyzaz). Desert nobles pay premium prices for silver jewelry — double to triple the Vlandian purchase price.
3. Buy desert horses, dates, and beer in Aserai towns. Dates and beer are cheap in the south and scarce in the north.
4. Travel north to Sturgian towns (Revyl, Varcheg). Sturgia has no horse production — desert horses sell for 2–3x the purchase price. Food goods like dates are also scarce in the snow.
5. Buy furs and hardwood in Sturgia. The snow forests produce cheap raw materials that southern nations lack.
6. Return to Vlandia and sell the furs and hardwood. Complete the cycle.

A full Silver Route cycle takes 10–15 in-game days and produces 15,000–30,000 denars profit depending on trade skill and market conditions.

emph{The Iron Circle} — a five-stop cycle focusing on smithing materials:

1. Buy iron ore from villages around Epicrotea and Diathma. These are the richest iron deposits in Calradia.
2. Sell iron ore to towns with smithies and active workshops — Zeonica, Onira, and Danustica all have high iron demand.
3. Buy tools and finished weapons from these smithy towns. A town that processes iron sells tools cheap.
4. Sell tools to villages. Every village buys tools for production upgrades. The demand is consistent and the margin is reliable.
5. Accumulate mules along the loop — mules increase your carrying capacity, and more capacity means more profit per trip. By the fourth cycle, a full mule train carries enough goods for 5,000+ denars profit per stop.

Trade Skill Perks

Trade perks improve your profit margins, unlock new capabilities, and at the highest levels fundamentally change what you can do in the economy.

Perk	Skill	Effect
Appraiser	25 Trade	Shows real market prices instead of color-coded indicators. Removes guesswork — you see exact profit-per-unit before buying. The single best early-game Trade perk.
Caravan Master	75 Trade	+30% profit from caravans you own. Mandatory for any character who runs caravans. Without this perk, caravans are a break-even proposition. With it, they are a reliable income stream.
Market Dealer	125 Trade	Reduces the trade penalty applied when buying low-supply goods. Normally, buying goods that a town has few of increases the price per unit — this perk halves that penalty.
Granary	225 Trade	Purchased grain automatically converts to party food stores. Eliminates the need to separately manage food supplies — buy grain in bulk and your party eats automatically. Essential for large armies on long campaigns.
Everything Has a Price	300 Trade	Allows you to buy and sell fiefs. The ultimate trade perk. With enough gold, you can purchase entire castles and towns from other lords, bypassing years of political maneuvering and siege warfare. Requires enormous capital — expect to pay 200,000–500,000 denars per fief.

Influence Management

Generating Influence

Influence is earned more efficiently than it is in Wave 0, because the activities that generate influence — large battles, sieges, and fief ownership — are exactly the activities Wave 1 is built around.

Source	Amount	Strategy
Winning battles	3–8 per battle	Seek out enemy parties equal to or smaller than your force. Even-odds battles generate influence efficiently and safely. Do not chase unwinnable fights — the influence gain is not worth the troop losses.
Successful sieges	10–20 per siege	The most efficient influence source in the game. One siege buys enough influence to fund an army for a week. Prioritize sieges when your influence pool is low.
High Charm	Passive daily	Invest focus points in Charm early. Each point generates influence passively every day — 200 Charm generates roughly 2–3 influence per day, which adds up to 700–1,000 influence per in-game year without fighting a single battle.
Forum building	Passive daily	The Forum is the best building in any fief. It generates 1–2 influence per day and stacks across multiple fiefs. Two fiefs with Forums generate as much influence as a minor battle every day.
Council of Commons policy	Modifier	Amplifies all influence generation. If this policy is active in your kingdom, the bonus applies to every influence source. Support this policy every time it comes to a vote.
Donating prisoners	Variable	After capturing nobles, donate them to an allied town's dungeon for influence. High-value prisoners (enemy faction leaders, high-tier clan members) grant 5–15 influence each. Do not ransom captured lords if you have a dungeon and need influence.

Spending Influence

Army cohesion is the primary influence drain. Leading a 1,000-man army costs 2–3 influence per day. A two-week siege campaign costs 28–42 influence just in cohesion. Add in the influence cost to summon lords (1–3 per clan, depending on their size and willingness), and a major military campaign can consume 80–120 influence. Pool 100 or more influence before committing to an extended campaign.

Voting costs 20–50 influence to propose policies. Overruling the council on a fief assignment costs 50–100 influence. The more you spend when claiming a fief, the more likely the council votes in your favor — think of it as a bid, not a flat cost. Spending 100 influence on a fief claim signals to the AI that you want it badly, and council members who already like you will support the claim.

Tip: Pool 100+ influence before joining a siege campaign. The cohesion cost alone will drain 30–50 influence over two weeks. If you start a campaign with 30 influence and the kingdom votes to continue the war, you become a spectator — unable to lead your army while other lords take the fiefs you bled for.

Influence Economy

Think of influence as a resource like gold, with earning, saving, and spending phases. Earn influence during peacetime through tournaments, bandit hunting, passive Charm generation, and Forum buildings. Hoard influence when you do not need to spend it — influence does not decay, so there is no cost to stockpiling. Spend aggressively during wartime — wars are when influence buys outcomes. Claim fiefs while they are available; the peace treaty will make them unavailable for months.

Protect your influence income. Oppose policies that reduce influence generation, especially Sacred Majesty and Royal Guard, which funnel influence to the ruler at vassal expense. If a policy reduces your influence generation by 20%, that is a permanent tax on every battle, siege, and building you own.

Danger: A kingdom out of influence cannot form armies. If the entire council runs dry, the kingdom cannot declare war, defend itself, or organize sieges. Never let your personal influence pool hit zero, and watch the kingdom's overall influence health — a faction with no influence is a faction about to lose territory.

Fief Development

When you own a fief, you are responsible for its development. A neglected fief starves, rebels, and eventually becomes someone else's problem. A well-managed fief becomes the economic engine that funds your wars.

Buildings Priority

Not all buildings are equal. Build order matters more than build variety — the first two projects determine whether your fief thrives or stagnates.

Priority	Building	Why
1	Fairgrounds	Always first. Fairgrounds increase loyalty by +1. Loyalty accelerates all future construction — each point of loyalty above 50 reduces construction time by roughly 5%. A Fairgrounds pays for its own build time within three subsequent projects.
2	Granary	Food storage prevents starvation during siege and winter. Starvation kills prosperity and loyalty — two stats that take months to recover. A Granary is cheap insurance against events you cannot control.
3	Workshop	Generates income. More prosperity means more income — the Workshop and prosperity form a virtuous cycle where each makes the other better. Build this third, after the foundation of loyalty and food security is established.
4	Militia Grounds	Generates free militia troops without wages. Militia do not cost denars per day like garrison troops — they are pure defense. Build this when you need protection but cannot afford a large garrison wage bill.
5	Walls	Upgrades siege defense rating. Build only if your fief is on a hostile border and you expect attacks. Walls take 60–90 days — you cannot afford this build time unless loyalty and food are already secured.
6	Siege Workshop	Faster siege engine construction when attacking from this fief. Useful only if the fief serves as a forward base for offensive campaigns. A niche building — prioritize the other five first.

Tip: Do not build everything at once. Most building projects take 30–60 days each at normal loyalty. Full development of a fief (all 6 buildings at Tier 3) takes roughly 1–2 in-game years.

Loyalty first, food second, income third. Everything else is a luxury you earn when the basics are stable.

Garrison Management

You pay daily wages for every soldier stationed in your fief's garrison, separate from your party's wage bill. Auto-recruitment automatically hires troops over time from visiting villagers and recruits. This sounds convenient — it is also a trap.

Quality matters more than quantity. Fifty Tier 3 troops hold a settlement more effectively than 100 Tier 1 recruits, and they cost roughly the same. Disable auto-recruitment and manually stock your garrisons with mid-tier troops recruited from your own culture. Seventy Tier 3 Imperial Infantrymen behind a Tier 2 wall will repel most siege assaults.

Set a wage limit of 500–1,000 denars per day per fief. In the Clan screen, under the Parties tab, you can set a maximum daily wage for each garrison. When the garrison's total wage bill exceeds this limit, auto-recruitment stops. Set this limit to match your passive income — if your workshops and caravans earn 1,500 denars per day, set your total garrison wage limit to 800–1,200, leaving room for party wages and personal expenses.

Warning: Garrison wages will bankrupt you if left unchecked. A 200-troop garrison of mixed tiers costs 800–1,400 denars per day. Two fiefs with unchecked garrisons drain 2,500 denars daily — 75,000 denars per in-game month. Check the Parties tab under Clan management weekly and adjust wage limits. If your garrison exceeds your limit, dismiss the lowest-tier troops first.

Governor Assignment

Assign a companion as governor through the Clan screen, under the Fiefs tab. The governor applies their skills as modifiers to the fief's stats.

Steward increases construction speed — a 150-Steward governor roughly doubles construction speed compared to no governor, making a 60-day project complete in roughly 30 days. Medicine increases prosperity growth rate, which accelerates tax and tariff income. Engineering improves wall strength and siege defenses. Charm increases loyalty, which accelerates everything else.

The single most impactful governor decision is culture match. If the fief's culture matches the governor's culture, the settlement gains +1 loyalty. A Battanian governor in a Battanian fief will always outperform a Sturgian governor with higher skills because the culture loyalty bonus compounds across every building project. When possible, assign governors whose culture matches the fief. The loyalty bonus is worth more than an extra 20 skill points in Steward.

Tip: The Governor role is the most demanding companion assignment. The companion is removed from your party permanently — they live in the fief, governed by their own AI. Do not assign your Surgeon, Scout, or Quartermaster companions as governors. Hire a dedicated governor companion from a tavern specifically for this purpose.

Clan Tier Progression

Reaching higher clan tiers unlocks more capabilities. Each tier is a gate that controls what you can do in the world.

Tier	Renown	Party Size	Unlocks
Tier 1	50	40	Mercenary contracts — you can be hired by factions as a mercenary.

Tier 2	150	60	Companion party x1, vassalage (can join a kingdom), workshops and caravans become available.
Tier 3	350	80	Companion party x2, can vote on kingdom policies. The minimum tier for meaningful political participation.
Tier 4	900	110	Companion party x3, you are now a major player — lords seek your opinion and fear your army.
Tier 5	2,100	140	Companion party x4, kingdom founding (can declare your own kingdom). The threshold for independent power.
Tier 6	5,000	180	Maximum tier. Full party size, maximum political weight. You are one of the most powerful individuals in Calradia.

Fastest Renown Sources

Renown is earned through deeds, and some deeds earn it faster than others. Even-odds battles produce the maximum renown per fight — the game's formula rewards battles where the player contributes significantly against a roughly equivalent force. Outnumbered victories earn more renown but carry higher risk of troop losses. If you want safe, consistent renown, pick fights equal to your own strength.

Tournaments are the most reliable safe renown source. A tournament victory earns 3–5 renown per win, takes 3–5 minutes, and carries zero risk. Participating in every tournament you pass during peacetime adds up to hundreds of renown over a campaign. Quest completions provide modest renown (1–3 per quest) but are useful in the early game when tournament frequency is limited by stamina and travel time.

Army participation earns renown based on your contribution. If you lead the siege that takes a castle, you earn the lion's share. If you join an existing army and contribute 15 troops to a 1,500-man battle, your renown gain is proportionally small. To maximize renown from army campaigns, lead the army yourself — the army leader earns the most renown from every battle and siege the army completes.

Mod List — Wave 1

Wave 1 expands the mod list to include **Graphics**, **Light mechanic**, and **Content addition** mods alongside continued **UI/QoL** improvements. No heavy overhauls — those are reserved for Wave 2.

Warning: Read each placeholder carefully. The examples listed are real mod types that fit the slot — but the actual mod chosen must be verified for compatibility with BL 1.4.x / WS 1.2.x before being added permanently.

=== Graphics Mod Placeholder

A Graphics mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Improved lighting engine with better ambient occlusion, bloom, and shadow cascades
- Time-of-day color grading that makes sunsets, dawn, and night more atmospheric
- Weather effects enhancement — rain, snow, and fog

Requirements: Must be compatible with other graphics mods. Target: stable 60+ FPS on NVIDIA RTX 3080 or equivalent at 1440p with high settings.

=== Graphics Mod Placeholder

A Graphics mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- High-resolution texture pack for terrain, buildings, and environments
- Improved armor and weapon textures for all faction troops
- Better character face and skin textures

Requirements: Target: 60 FPS at 1440p on RTX 3080 (10GB VRAM) or equivalent. Must not conflict with equipment mods.

=== **Graphics Mod Placeholder**

A Graphics mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Higher-poly character heads with better expressions and skin shading
- Improved hair and beard rendering
- Better body proportions and armor fitting

Requirements: Must be compatible with any character creation mods in this wave. Target: 60 FPS at 1440p on RTX 3080 or equivalent.

=== **UI/QoL Mod Placeholder**

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Search and filter functionality for the in-game encyclopedia
- Show troop upgrade trees with stat comparisons
- Track relationship changes, quest history, and notable interactions

Requirements: Must not alter any underlying game data — display and search only.

=== **UI/QoL Mod Placeholder**

A UI/QoL mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Free camera mode in battles (spectator and replay)
- Customizable key bindings for formation commands
- Better death cam — follow your killer or your troops after death

Requirements: Must not allow control of troops after death (no cheating/god-mode).

=== **Light mechanic Mod Placeholder**

A Light mechanic mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Non-aggression pacts, defensive alliances, and trade agreements between kingdoms
- Peace treaty duration enforcement — prevents immediate re-declaration of war
- Messenger system — send diplomatic proposals without traveling to the ruler

Requirements: Must not override core kingdom mechanics. Must integrate with BL 1.4.7's faction AI. Diplomacy should be earned, not bought.

=== **Light mechanic Mod Placeholder**

A Light mechanic mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Better AI battle tactics — enemy lords use formations, flanking, and terrain
- Improved AI decision-making for declaring war and making peace
- AI lords manage their fiefs and parties more efficiently

Requirements: Must not make the game unfair. AI should be smarter, not omniscient. Must still be beatable by a skilled player on normal difficulty.

=== **Light mechanic Mod Placeholder**

A Light mechanic mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- More varied tournament prizes including named weapons and armor
- Different tournament formats (team fights, archery contests, jousting)
- Arena betting with dynamic odds based on your reputation

Requirements: Must not make tournaments a primary income source — prizes should be cosmetic or sidegrade-tier, not best-in-slot.

=== **Light mechanic Mod Placeholder**

A Light mechanic mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Bandit parties scale with game time — late-game bandit armies instead of irrelevant looters
- Minor factions have unique troops, leaders, and motivations instead of being generic
- Bandit hideouts have more variety and better rewards for clearing them

Requirements: Must not make bandits overpower players in early game. Scaling should match clan tier progression.

=== **Light mechanic Mod Placeholder**

A Light mechanic mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Settlements slowly adopt the culture of their owner over time
- Cultural bonuses for troops recruited in their native regions
- Cultural festivals and events that affect prosperity and loyalty

Requirements: Must not allow instant culture conversion. Change should take multiple in-game years.

=== Content addition Mod Placeholder

A Content addition mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Additional historically-inspired armor sets for each faction
- More weapon variety — different sword types, polearms, and bows
- New horse breeds with distinct stats and appearances

Requirements: Must not add overpowered items. New equipment should be sidegrades to existing items, not strict upgrades. Must be compatible with texture mods.

=== Content addition Mod Placeholder

A Content addition mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Additional troop upgrade paths for all factions
- Noble troops have more distinct specializations from common troops
- Unique troop types for minor factions and mercenary companies

Requirements: Must maintain faction identity. Vlandian troops should not become better archers than Battanians. Must not create unbeatable combinations.

=== Content addition Mod Placeholder

A Content addition mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- More companion variety — different backgrounds, skills, and personalities
- Companions have personal quests and storylines
- More named NPCs in the world with unique dialogue and interactions

Requirements: Must not add companions that trivialize early game. Dialogue must not conflict with the game's tone.

Load Order — Wave 1

The correct load order for all Wave 1 mods, listed from top to bottom. Mods loaded first appear at the top; mods loaded last override and appear at the bottom.

Warning: The load order is a suggested template based on placeholder mods. When real mods are added, update this table with actual mod names and verified positions. Load order is critical in Wave 1 — mods that affect the same systems must be ordered correctly to avoid overrides and conflicts.

Load Order Rules (Wave 1)

1. **UI/QoL mods:** Load first — they should not override game mechanics
2. **Graphics mods:** Load after UI/QoL — they affect rendering, not logic
3. **Content addition mods:** Load after graphics — new items and troops must load before mods that modify them

4. **Light mechanic mods:** Load last — they modify game systems and need to see the full content stack

Position	Category	Mod	Notes
1.	UI/QoL	Enhanced Encyclopedia	UI-only, loads first to avoid conflicts
2.	UI/QoL	Battle Camera & Controls	UI-only, independent
3.	Graphics	Lighting & Atmosphere	Rendering layer, must load before texture mods
4.	Graphics	Texture Enhancement	Replaces base textures
5.	Graphics	Character Models	Depends on texture mod for base textures
6.	Content addition	New Equipment	Adds items before troop mods reference them
7.	Content addition	Expanded Troop Trees	References equipment from New Equipment
8.	Content addition	Companions & NPCs	Independent content addition
9.	Light mechanic	Diplomacy Expansion	Modifies kingdom diplomacy layer
10.	Light mechanic	Improved AI	Modifies game logic — loads after content
11.	Light mechanic	Tournament & Arena	Modifies tournament logic
12.	Light mechanic	Bandit & Minor Faction	Modifies faction logic
13.	Light mechanic	Culture & Settlement	Modifies settlement logic — loads last to override culture systems

WAVE 2

The Reckoning

Introduction

You have crossed the mountains. It took longer than you imagined — months of campaigning, three sieges, two betrayals, and a battle in a valley that still gives you nightmares — but you are here. The banners of your allies stretch across the fields before your ancestral keep. Vlandians in their heavy plate. Battanians with their longbows strung. Even a company of Khuzait horse archers, hired at ruinous expense, their arrows tipped with Thamaskene steel.

Your uncle sits behind those walls. His spies told him you were coming weeks ago — there was no hiding an army of this size. He has pulled every garrison from every holding he still controls. The siege engines you see on the battlements are the same ones your father commissioned, years before the betrayal. The men on those walls are the sons of the men who killed your family. Some of them know who you are. Some of them remember.

Let them remember.

You could send an envoy. You could demand surrender, offer terms, negotiate a bloodless transfer of power. The diplomat in you — the part that learned charm and persuasion in a hundred quiet conversations — whispers that this is the smart play. The smart play preserves lives. The smart play preserves the kingdom you will inherit.

But the smart play is not why you came here.

You did not cross half a continent and spill rivers of blood to sit at a negotiation table with the man who murdered your family. You did not build an army, forge alliances, and earn the loyalty of thousands to sign a treaty that lets him keep his head. You came here for one thing, and you will have it, and no power in Calradia will stand between you and it.

The crown does not exist yet. Your father never wore one — he was a baron, not a king. But you will forge it yourself, from the melted-down swords of your enemies, and you will place it on your own head because no one else has the right. No crown is given. No crown is earned. No crown comes without blood.

Let it be blood.

Wave 2 Objectives

Wave 2 is total war. Your goals:

1. Found or claim a kingdom and lead it to dominance over Calradia
2. Master mass-scale warfare — coordinate multiple armies across multiple fronts
3. Manage kingdom-level politics — vassals, policies, and internal stability
4. Build an economic empire that funds constant war
5. Assemble the strongest possible army with endgame-tier troops and equipment
6. Achieve total victory — whether that means conquering the map or achieving your personal objective

What Changes in Wave 2

Wave 2 is the heaviest mod experience:

1. **Heavy overhaul mods:** Core systems are changed. Economy, combat, diplomacy, and kingdom management may work differently from vanilla.
2. **All previous categories:** Graphics, UI/QoL, light mechanics, and content additions also apply. Wave 2 includes everything from Wave 1 plus overhauls.
3. **Maximum mod count:** Wave 2 has the most mods of any wave. Load order management is critical.

Danger: Wave 2 is designed for veteran players who understand every mechanic from Waves 0 and 1. If you have not completed (or at least extensively played) Wave 1, Wave 2 will be overwhelming and likely frustrating. The difficulty is higher, the systems are deeper, and the margin for error is razor-thin.

Your Character, Ascended

You are no longer the refugee child or the ambitious mercenary. You are a warlord:

- **Age:** Mid-to-late twenties (approximately 10 years after the massacre)
- **Skills:** Your build should be complete. You have invested in every attribute and every skill that matters for your playstyle. Specialize ruthlessly — a generalist is a dead generalist in Wave 2.
- **Reputation:** Your renown is high and your enemies are many. Lords remember your victories, your betrayals, and your grudges. Every diplomatic interaction is weighted by years of history.
- **Starting wealth:** You begin with significant resources — 50,000+ denars, workshops, and caravans. You are not building from scratch; you are deploying existing wealth.

Difficulty

Wave 2 recommends maximum difficulty settings:

Setting	Wave 2 Value
Player Received Damage	Realistic (100%) — every hit matters
Troop Received Damage	Realistic — your troops are mortal
Recruitment Difficulty	Realistic — no recruitment shortcuts
Combat AI Difficulty	Veteran — enemies use Wave 2 modded AI at full capacity
Ironman Mode	Recommended — no savescumming, live with your decisions
Clan Member Death	Enabled — companions and family can die permanently

Tip: If Ironman mode feels too punishing during your first Wave 2 attempt, start with Normal saving. Wave 2 is difficult enough without the fear of permanent death. Turn Ironman on when you feel confident in your kingdom's stability.

Strategy — Wave 2

You have fought battles. You have won wars. You have built a kingdom from nothing. Now you must manage it — and expand it — at a scale where your personal sword matters less than your strategic mind.

Endgame Warfare

The battles of Wave 2 are not skirmishes. They are campaigns involving thousands of troops across multiple armies and multiple fronts.

Multi-Army Strategy

At Clan Tier 4 and above, your military capacity is formidable. Your personal party, plus companion parties, plus allied lords summoned to your army, can easily exceed 1,000 troops in a single host. A

thousand men under one banner is a hammer capable of shattering any single enemy army. But one hammer can only hit one target at a time, and the enemies of a mid-sized kingdom rarely oblige by presenting a single target.

The solution is a two-army doctrine. Army A, the Offensive Army, is led by you personally. It contains your best troops — your elite cavalry, your veteran archers, your Fian Champions and Imperial Legionaries that have survived a hundred battles. This army exists to capture territory. It sieges towns, smashes enemy field armies, and applies pressure where the enemy is weakest. It moves where you direct it and fights what you choose to fight.

Army B, the Defensive Army, is led by a trusted companion or a high-relation allied lord. Its composition is different — more infantry, more archers, less cavalry. Cavalry wins battles on the offensive. Infantry holds ground on the defensive. Army B patrols your border regions, responds to enemy raids, breaks small incursions before they become sieges, and holds threatened fiefs long enough for Army A to pivot back from its campaign.

The two-army doctrine has one non-negotiable rule: Army B must be large enough to survive contact with an enemy army of equal size for at least forty-eight in-game hours. If Army B has 400 troops and an enemy 600-man army crosses your border, Army B needs to hold them in a defensive siege long enough for you to march Army A back. If Army B is crushed in a single field battle, you return to find your border already overrun and the enemy sieging your interior towns. Size Army B proportionally to your most dangerous neighbor — if the Western Empire fields 800-man armies, your Defensive Army needs 500+ troops to buy you the march time home.

Tip: A kingdom that commits 100% of its military to offense will lose its home territory to enemy raids. The AI punishes undefended borders — enemy lords check your garrison strengths and attack the weakest. You do not need to match every border army man-for-man. You need one competent Defensive Army that can slow the enemy down until you, or a peace treaty, arrives.

War Target Selection

Do not fight everyone at once. The kingdoms of Calradia will, given the opportunity, drag you into multi-front wars where your armies are stretched thin and your enemies converge. The only defense against this is choosing your wars based on clear, consistent criteria before you declare them.

Geographic adjacency is the first filter. Attack kingdoms that share a border with you. A war against a faction on the far side of the map means your armies march for seven days before they see an enemy, while your home territory sits undefended against your actual neighbors. Distant wars drain army cohesion, exhaust your vassals, and produce captured fiefs that are isolated enclaves impossible to defend. Every fief you take should be connected to territory you already hold. A kingdom shaped like Swiss cheese is a kingdom that loses territory every time someone sneezes.

Enemy war exhaustion is the second filter. Check the diplomacy screen before every war declaration. A faction already fighting two or more simultaneous wars is an easy target — its armies are already committed elsewhere, its lords are already wounded or captured, and its garrisons are already depleted. Your declaration is the tipping point that overwhelms their remaining capacity. A faction at peace with full garrisons and healthy armies is a much harder target. Patience is a strategic weapon: wait for the Southern Empire to overextend against the Khuzait, then strike when their eastern garrisons are empty.

Settlement value is the third filter. Not all conquests are equal. High-prosperity towns — 5,000 prosperity and above — are the prize. They generate tax revenue that funds your next war, they provide troop recruitment for your next army, and they project power across the surrounding region. Castles are secondary objectives at best. A castle controls a choke point or produces a resource, but it generates minimal income and requires constant garrison wages. Conquering a castle that costs 800 denars per

day in garrison while earning 150 denars in taxes is a net loss. Take the towns first, then the castles that protect them.

Choke points are the fourth filter. Castles that sit on mountain passes, river crossings, or narrow coastal roads control movement across entire regions. A single castle at the right mountain pass can block an entire faction from entering your territory. Prioritize these over castles in open plains — a castle you cannot bypass is worth more than three castles you can ride around.

Sustaining an Offensive

The biggest challenge in endgame warfare is not winning battles — it is keeping your army in the field long enough to win the war. A battle lasts twenty minutes. A siege lasts two weeks. The logistics of sustaining an army for two weeks in enemy territory will determine whether your campaign succeeds.

Food supply is your primary constraint. A 1,000-man army consumes roughly 20 to 30 units of food per day depending on composition — cavalry-heavy armies eat more because horses consume grain. Your party carries a food reserve that depletes continuously, and when it hits zero, your troops begin to starve. Starving troops take morale penalties, then desert. A starving army can lose 50 men per day to desertion, and those men take their expensive equipment with them. The siege that you were winning on day eight becomes unwinnable on day twelve because half your army walked away.

The solution is a three-part supply chain. First, assign a high-Steward companion as your Quartermaster — Steward skill directly reduces food consumption rate, and a 200-Steward Quartermaster can stretch the same food supply to feed 30% more troops. Second, capture enemy villages near your siege for emergency food — a single village provides 50 to 100 units of food, enough for several days of operation. Third, understand seasonal effects: winter multiplies food consumption across the board. Besieging a town in midwinter is a race against your own stomach. Besieging in autumn, when harvests are in and food is abundant, gives you the margin you need.

Reinforcement pipelines are your second constraint. Sieges cost lives. Even a successful siege assault against an undermanned garrison will kill 30 to 80 of your troops — more if the defenders are reinforced or the walls are undamaged. You need a way to replace those losses without marching back to your capital. Maintain garrisons of trained mid-tier troops in your core fiefs — 50 to 100 men per fief, culture-matched to your army composition. When you need reinforcements, assign a companion party to ferry troops from your core fiefs to the front. The companion rides back, collects troops from multiple garrisons, and returns. This pipeline takes five to ten in-game days depending on distance, so plan resupply before your army reaches critical depletion.

Rotation of wounded is the third constraint. After every major battle, a significant fraction of your troops are wounded, occupying party slots but unable to fight. Transfer wounded to a companion party and send them to the nearest friendly town to recover while you press the offensive with healthy troops. The companion returns with fresh troops from garrison reserves, completing the rotation cycle. This keeps your offensive army at full combat strength while casualties recover behind the lines.

Warning: Sieging in enemy territory is the single most dangerous logistics challenge in Bannerlord. You are stationary for up to two weeks while enemy armies maneuver. You need enough food to outlast the defenders' supplies — a town with a full Granary can hold out for 30 days or more. If your food runs out before the town's, you lose the siege, your army starves, and the enemy relief force catches you retreating with half morale and no supplies. Budget food for the full expected siege duration plus a 50% safety margin.

Kingdom Management

Congratulations — you are the ruler. Every problem in the kingdom is now your problem.

Vassal Management

Vassals are the muscle of your kingdom. Without vassals, your kingdom is a single clan fighting a continent, and a single clan cannot be everywhere at once. With vassals, your kingdom operates multiple armies, patrols multiple borders, and prosecutes multiple wars. The quality of your vassal management determines whether your kingdom is a coalition or a collection of malcontents waiting to leave.

Grant fiefs after sieges, and grant them to the vassals who contributed troops to the siege effort. The participation score — calculated from troop count, siege engine contribution, and time spent in the siege camp — determines who the game considers most deserving. Following this score keeps your vassals content. Overruling it to give the fief to yourself or a favorite costs influence and relation. Overruling it repeatedly signals to your vassals that their contributions do not matter, and vassals who feel unappreciated start looking for a new liege.

Do not hoard fiefs. A landed vassal is a productive vassal — they upgrade their holdings, garrison their borders, and generate income that funds their own war parties. A landless vassal is restless. If a vassal has zero fiefs and the kingdom has gone three wars without granting them one, they will defect. The relationship formula is simple: one fief equals content; three fiefs equals loyal for life; zero fiefs equals a defection timer counting down.

Support pro-vassal policies while your position as ruler is still consolidating. Noble Retinues, Council of Commons, and Citizenship all benefit vassals directly, and a vassal who feels their king supports their interests is less likely to join a rebellion. Once your kingdom is stable and your treasury is full, you can reconsider policies that consolidate power to the crown — but early in your reign, the crown's power is the sum of its vassals' loyalty.

Vote with your vassals on decisions they care about, even when you have the influence to override them. Every vote cast against a vassal costs relation with that vassal's entire clan. A vote cast with them builds relation. Relation is a resource that prevents defection, accelerates army recruitment, and determines whether vassals support your fief claims. Spend it only when the outcome is critical. If you do not care who gets a minor border castle, vote with the majority and bank the relation.

Danger: Vassals defecting during a war can turn a winning campaign into a losing one overnight. A vassal clan that leaves takes its fiefs with it — those fiefs become enemy territory, your border collapses, and the enemy suddenly has a new ally who knows exactly where your garrisons are weakest. Monitor relation levels of border vassals every few in-game weeks. A vassal whose relationship drops below -20 should be your top diplomatic priority — grant them a fief, support their policy preferences, or marry a family member into their clan to restore the buffer zone.

Internal Stability

A kingdom that is not stable internally cannot fight wars externally. Internal stability is governed primarily by settlement loyalty, and loyalty is governed by a set of mechanics you must manage across every fief in your realm.

Loyalty is affected by five primary factors. **Culture match** between the settlement and its owner and/or governor — each matching culture grants +1 loyalty per day. A Battanian-owned Battanian-culture town with a Battanian governor enjoys +2 loyalty per day from culture match alone. An Imperial-owned Battanian town with an Aserai governor suffers -2 loyalty per day. **Security**, representing the garrison's ability to suppress unrest — the larger the garrison relative to the settlement's population, the higher the security bonus. A fully garrisoned town of 200 troops against a population of 5,000 generates a security bonus of roughly +1 to +2 loyalty. **Policies** — certain kingdom policies directly affect loyalty (Citizenship grants +0.5, Imperial Towns penalizes -1). **Recent ownership** — a newly captured settlement suffers a -3 loyalty penalty that decays over approximately thirty in-game days as

the populace adjusts to their new ruler. **Starvation** — zero food in a settlement causes rapid loyalty decay, roughly -1 per day, which will trigger rebellion within weeks if unresolved.

Rebellions trigger when loyalty drops below a critical threshold — approximately 15 to 20 — and remains there for an extended period. When a rebellion triggers, the town or castle declares independence and spawns a rebel army roughly equal in size to the garrison plus the local militia. The settlement becomes a hostile minor faction, and you must reconquer it. A reconquered settlement starts at zero loyalty with the full -3 recent ownership penalty, meaning a second rebellion is nearly guaranteed unless you invest aggressively in recovery.

Prevent rebellion through a layered approach. First, assign a culture-matched governor — this is the single most impactful action and costs nothing except one companion. Second, build Fairgrounds — the +1 loyalty bonus accelerates construction of everything else. Third, maintain an adequate garrison — set an auto-recruitment cap of roughly 100 to 150 troops for an interior town, 200 to 250 for a border town. Fourth, fund the Festival event during the crisis period after conquest — festivals convert denars into temporary loyalty boosts, expensive but essential when a settlement is hovering at 10 loyalty and you cannot survive a rebellion. Fifth, avoid stacking negative-loyalty policies. If your kingdom has Imperial Towns and Debasement of Currency active simultaneously, every town in your realm is fighting a -2 loyalty penalty before any positive modifiers apply.

Warning: Multi-front wars cripple your ability to suppress rebellions. A rebellion in a border town during a three-front war is an existential crisis — you cannot pull an army away from any front without losing territory on that front, but if you ignore the rebellion, the town declares independence and becomes a fourth front. The safe approach is to ensure every fief has at least +2 net loyalty before you commit to a multi-front campaign. If you are capturing territory faster than you can stabilize it, you are losing.

Vassal Defection Prevention

Vassal defection is governed by a three-pillar system that determines a clan's willingness to remain in your kingdom.

The first pillar is **relation**. Your personal relationship with each vassal clan leader is the primary factor. A relation of +50 or above is the safe zone — vassals at this level will not defect even during prolonged wars or after multiple fief disputes. A relation between -20 and +50 is the neutral zone — vassals will stay as long as conditions are favorable but may defect if the war turns against you or if they go too long without a fief grant. A relation below -20 is the danger zone — these vassals are actively looking for an opportunity to leave, and they will find one within a few in-game months.

The second pillar is **fief count**. One to three fiefs is the content range — the vassal has enough land to generate income and feel invested in the kingdom. Zero fiefs is restless — within a few months, a landless vassal will announce their intention to leave, and you will have a short window (roughly a week) to grant them a fief before they defect. Four or more fiefs makes a vassal essentially permanent — they have so much invested in the kingdom that leaving would cost them more than staying could ever gain.

The third pillar is **shared enemies**. Vassals gain relation with you for every battle you fight together against the same enemy. If the kingdom is at war with Vlandia and you personally fight alongside a vassal's army against Vlandian lords, that vassal's relation with you rises. Conversely, vassals who never see you on the battlefield feel disconnected from the kingdom. A ruler who sits in the capital while vassals fight the wars loses relation through neglect.

Beyond the three pillars, marriage provides a permanent relation buffer. Marry your sister to a vassal's son, and that vassal's entire clan gains a permanent +10 to +20 relation with you that never decays. This is the nuclear option for securing a wavering vassal — expensive in political capital, but

permanent. Multiple marriages across multiple vassal clans create a web of relations that makes mass defection nearly impossible. A vassal whose sister is married to your brother will not defect unless conditions are catastrophic.

Tip: Non-aggression pacts and trade agreements do not affect vassal loyalty. They are agreements between kingdoms, not bonds within one. A vassal protected by a non-aggression pact with the neighboring kingdom will still defect to that kingdom if their relation with you is bad enough.

Advanced Diplomacy

Alliance Networks

Mutual defense pacts — alliances — coordinate your wars with allied kingdoms. When you ally with another kingdom, your wars become their wars and vice versa. When Vlandia declares war on you, your Battanian allies declare war on Vlandia automatically. When the Northern Empire attacks the Battanians, you are automatically at war with the Northern Empire. Alliance networks can transform a losing war into an even fight and an even fight into a rout — but they come with costs.

The primary cost of an alliance is entanglement in wars you did not choose. If your ally is aggressive, an alliance with them means constant war. Each declaration by your ally drags your kingdom into a conflict that may be on the far side of the map, against an enemy who has no quarrel with you, at a time when you desperately need peace to recover from your last campaign. You cannot refuse — the alliance treaty obligates you to honor the war declaration, and refusing breaks the alliance with massive relation penalties and a long cooldown before you can ally again.

The secondary cost is the political friction of alliance. When you are allied to Battania and the Western Empire simultaneously, and those two allies go to war with each other, you must choose which alliance to honor and which to break. You will lose one ally, and the kingdom you abandon will remember it for a generation.

The strategic rule of alliances is simple: only ally with kingdoms you share a border with. A distant ally cannot send armies to help you — the march time means their armies arrive after your war is already won or lost. But a distant ally can drag you into their regional wars, forcing you to march your armies across the map while your borders sit undefended. Border allies reinforce each other in days, not weeks. Their wars are your wars geographically, not just diplomatically.

Tip: Alliance with a neighboring kingdom that shares your primary enemy is the most valuable diplomatic relationship in the game. If you border Vlandia and the Battanians border Vlandia, an alliance means Vlandia fights a two-front war every time they declare on either of you. The AI cannot handle two-front wars effectively — their armies will shuttle between fronts and accomplish nothing on either.

Strategic Betrayals

Betrayal is a tool. It has a cost that must be weighed against its gains, and the cost compounds — each betrayal makes the next one more expensive.

The optimal moment to betray an ally or break a non-aggression pact is when the target is already at war with multiple factions. Check the diplomacy screen. If the Western Empire is fighting the Northern Empire, the Battanians, and the Vlandians simultaneously, their armies are already committed on three fronts. Your declaration is the fourth front they cannot cover. Their border towns are ungarrisoned. Their lords are captured or recovering. Your armies sweep through their territory before they can organize resistance. This is the betrayal that wins a war in weeks.

The second window of vulnerability opens immediately after a peace treaty. Garrisons are depleted from the war just ended. Armies are dispersed and recovering. Lords are wounded. The kingdom is not expecting a new war — the AI's threat assessment resets after peace, and border garrisons take weeks to rebuild. Declaring war in this window means you fight a weakened enemy on your schedule, not theirs.

The cost of betrayal is reputation damage across all factions, not just your target. Every faction tracks your reliability as a diplomatic partner. Betray one ally, and future alliance proposals cost more influence, require higher starting relations, and face more council opposition. Betray two, and kingdoms that previously accepted non-aggression pacts now refuse. Betray three, and you are diplomatically isolated — no one will ally, no one will sign a pact, and every neighbor assumes you will eventually betray them. Betrayal is a weapon with limited ammunition. Use it for wars that matter, not for every minor border skirmish.

Non-Aggression Pacts

Non-aggression pacts are defensive diplomacy. A pact with a neighboring kingdom means that kingdom will not declare war on you for the pact's duration. This does not prevent you from declaring war on them — the pact only restricts the AI's behavior, not yours. If you declare on a kingdom with whom you have a pact, the pact is broken and you suffer the same reputation penalty as any betrayal.

The primary use of non-aggression pacts is securing one border while you expand on another. A kingdom bordered by three factions on three sides needs to fight them one at a time. A pact with the faction on your western border means your western territory is safe while your armies campaign east. When the eastern campaign is complete and that border is stable, you can pivot west — the pact will have expired or you can break it when you are ready to fight on that front.

Pacts cost influence to propose and must pass a council vote. The influence cost is moderate — comparable to proposing a policy — and the council vote is usually favorable if the target kingdom is not a traditional enemy of your faction. Pacts with traditional enemies (Vlandia and Battania, or Empire and Khuzait) may fail council votes repeatedly.

Succession Planning

Heirs

Children born from your marriage become playable clan members after approximately 18 in-game years pass. This is a multi-decade investment — the child you produce in year five of your campaign will not become playable until year twenty-three. In a standard-length campaign where total victory is achieved in ten to fifteen in-game years, you will never play as your child unless you deliberately extend the game past its natural conclusion.

Education matters during the waiting period. Assign a guardian companion to each child — the child inherits skill experience multipliers from their guardian, biasing their development toward the guardian's strengths. A child assigned to a 200-Steward guardian will develop Steward faster than other skills. A child assigned to a 200-Tactics guardian will favor military development. Choose guardians strategically based on the role you want each child to play when they come of age — one heir for stewardship and governance, one spare for military command.

Tip: Children are a multi-decade investment. Do not expect to play as them unless you are running an exceptionally long campaign or using mods that accelerate the aging mechanic. Treat children as a roleplaying element, a succession safety net in case your main character dies with death enabled, and a source of marriage alliances. Their strategic impact is generational, not immediate.

Clan Longevity

A clan with multiple adult family members is a clan that survives disasters. If your main character dies in battle with clan member death enabled, you continue playing as your spouse or an adult family member. A clan that consists of one character and seven companions dies permanently when that character falls. A clan with a spouse, two adult siblings, and three adult children has five backup protagonists and can lose characters without losing the game.

Spread marriage alliances across multiple factions. Marry your brother to a Vlandian clan, your sister to a Battanian one, and your heir to an Imperial noble house. When one faction betrays you, the other two marriages may preserve those alliances. When Vlandia declares war, your Battanian in-laws vote against the declaration because they do not want to fight their sister's kingdom. Marriage networks create diplomatic cushioning that absorbs shocks before they become crises.

Clan Longevity

Multiple family members mean multiple party leaders, multiple governors, and multiple backup characters if your main one dies. Each adult family member can lead a party — your spouse leads one army while you lead another, and your adult siblings lead companion-tier parties. Each family member can govern a fief with culture-matching bonuses. A large clan is a distributed military and administrative apparatus, not just a collection of relatives.

Spread marriage alliances strategically across factions. A brother married to a Vlandian clan and a sister married to a Battanian one creates diplomatic redundancy. When Vlandia betrays you, the Battanian alliance may hold. When one marriage burns, another marriage may save you. This is long-term insurance — marriages take years to arrange and decades to pay dividends, but a clan that has been building marriage ties for two generations is a clan that cannot be isolated.

Total War Logistics

Food Supply Chains

Army-scale consumption is the limiting factor on every campaign. A 1,000-man army eats between 20 and 30 units of food per day depending on composition — cavalry armies eat more, infantry armies eat less. Your party's food inventory depletes continuously at this rate. A captured village provides a one-time food injection of roughly 50 to 100 units, enough for two to five days of operations. After the village is stripped, you need a new food source or you need to retreat.

Plan resupply points every three to four days of marching. This means identifying villages along your campaign route that will still have food when you arrive — villages that the enemy has not already stripped, villages in regions where crops have ripened, villages that are not currently under siege. A campaign plan without resupply points is a starvation plan.

Seasonal effects are decisive. Autumn is the season of abundance — crops have been harvested, villages are full, and food is cheap and plentiful. Siege in autumn if you have a choice. Winter multiplies food consumption by roughly 1.5x, making every day of winter campaigning exponentially more expensive in supplies. Besieging in winter is a race against your own logistics — if the siege lasts more than seven days in deep winter, your army will starve before the town surrenders. Summer and spring are transitional — less food than autumn, less penalty than winter, the baseline for campaign planning.

Warning: Do not besiege in winter unless you have overwhelming food reserves and a Quartermaster with 200+ Steward. The food penalty is multiplicative — the same siege that costs 300 food in autumn costs 450+ food in winter. If you misjudge, your army starves, the siege fails, and you lose weeks of campaign progress.

Reinforcement Pipelines

Wars are won by the last army standing, not the first army that attacks. Maintaining combat strength across a campaign requires a reinforcement pipeline that delivers fresh troops to the front without requiring the commander to return to home territory.

Companion parties function as couriers. Send a companion from your offensive army back to your core fiefs. The companion stops at each of your garrison towns and transfers troops from the garrison to their party. When full, the companion returns to the front and merges with your army. The time cost is the round-trip march time — five to ten in-game days from a distant front to your capital and back. This means you must anticipate losses four to six days before they become critical and send the courier early.

Garrison rotation is the second mechanism. Maintain garrisons of trained troops — not raw recruits — in your core fiefs. Fifty to 100 mid-tier troops per fief, culture-matched to your army composition. These garrisons are your strategic reserve. When a frontline fief is threatened, transfer troops from the reserve to the front. When a frontline fief is quiet, transfer surplus garrison troops back to the reserve. The rotation keeps your best troops where the fighting is hottest.

Troop training time is the hidden cost. A trained troop is the product of weeks of recruitment, upgrade, and combat survival. Every troop lost in a siege or a field battle is weeks of production time destroyed in minutes. The reinforcement pipeline must be producing and stockpiling troops during peacetime so that you have reserves when war starts. A kingdom that only starts recruiting when war is declared fights its first campaign with raw recruits against veteran enemies.

War Exhaustion

Even victorious wars have a cost, and the cost is measured in influence, morale, and vassal patience — the three currencies of war exhaustion.

Influence drain is the most immediate cost. Raising and maintaining armies costs influence per day of cohesion. A 1,000-man army on a two-week siege campaign costs 30 to 50 influence in cohesion alone. Summoning additional lords costs more. Proposing continued war when the council wants peace costs influence to override. When your kingdom's influence pool runs dry, no one can form armies, no one can propose policies, and the kingdom drifts aimlessly while enemies retake lost territory. Watch the kingdom's collective influence before committing to extended campaigns.

Troop morale degrades during long campaigns. Morale decays faster when food is low, when casualties are high, and when the army has been away from home territory for extended periods. Low morale reduces combat effectiveness — troops route faster and fight with less damage. An army that has been on campaign for six continuous months has lower morale than an army that is fresh out of garrison rest. Rotate armies — send one army home to recover morale while a fresh army takes over the front.

Vassal fatigue is the political cost of constant war. Vassals want peacetime to manage their fiefs, upgrade their buildings, and recover their party strength. A vassal whose party has been at war for twelve straight months has not had time to upgrade their town, train their garrison, or pursue personal objectives. Vassals who are perpetually at war accumulate resentment and become more likely to defect. The cycle is: six to twelve months of war for territorial gains, three to six months of peace for recovery and consolidation. This cycle keeps vassals content, armies strong, and influence pools full. A kingdom that fights continuously for two years will face mass defections regardless of how many wars it is winning.

Map-Painting Strategy

Conquest Order

The order in which you conquer your enemies matters more than how fast you conquer them. The strategic priority is: weakest faction first, strongest faction last.

Eliminate minor and weakened factions first. A faction that has already lost half its territory in previous wars is fighting from a disadvantage — low clan tier, depleted garrisons, fewer lords. Finish what their previous enemies started. Eliminating a faction completely removes them from the diplomatic map: no more war declarations from that direction, no more border to defend, no more potential allies for your remaining enemies. Every faction eliminated is a border removed from your strategic calculations.

Encirclement is the second principle. Capture territory that surrounds your remaining enemies. A faction whose territory is completely encircled by your kingdom cannot recruit from outside their borders, cannot trade without passing through your towns, and cannot send armies anywhere without walking through your territory. Encirclement turns every subsequent war into a siege of their remaining holdings — they cannot relieve each other, cannot reinforce, and cannot escape.

The absolute rule: never fight a two-front war by choice. If circumstances force a two-front war — an ally declares war while you are already committed — prioritize finishing one front before engaging the other. Half-measures on both fronts lose both. A kingdom that commits 60% of its forces to one front and 40% to the other will lose on both. The correct play is 100% commitment to the more dangerous front, accept territorial losses on the secondary front, and pivot when the primary enemy is broken.

Choke Points

Specific castles control movement across entire regions. A castle built at a mountain pass — the passes connecting Battania to Vlandia, the narrow corridors between the Empire and the Aserai desert — blocks the only path an army can take. An enemy faction whose access to your territory is blocked by a mountain-pass castle has exactly two options: siege the castle, or not enter your territory. There is no third option.

River bridges function similarly. A castle at a bridge crossing forces armies to either attack the castle or find another crossing — and another crossing may be days of marching away in the wrong direction. A well-garrisoned bridge castle can delay an entire invasion by a week, buying you the time to redeploy your offensive army to the threatened sector.

Garrison choke points heavily. A castle that controls a mountain pass or a bridge needs 200+ troops, not the 60 a standard garrison would hold. The cost in garrison wages is the cost of border security — compare 800 denars per day for a heavily garrisoned choke point against losing three interior towns to enemy raids because the enemy bypassed a lightly garrisoned position. The math favors the heavy garrison every time.

Vassal Distribution

Where you place your vassals' fiefs determines how effectively your kingdom can defend itself. Assign border fiefs to military-focused clans. A clan whose leader has high Tactics, Leadership, and combat skills will naturally produce and lead larger parties, patrol their border territory, and respond to raids without your direct orders. Their personal combat effectiveness translates into border security for your kingdom.

Assign interior fiefs to economy-focused clans. A clan whose leader has high Steward, Trade, and Charm will maximize prosperity, tax revenue, and construction speed in their holdings. Their economic output funds the military clans on the border. Interior vassals produce the money — border vassals spend it on defense.

Give neighboring fiefs to the same clan whenever possible. A clan that holds three adjacent castles and a town in the same region will defend that region as a unit. Their parties patrol the contiguous

territory. Their garrisons reinforce each other. An enemy cannot pick off one fief without engaging the entire clan's military apparatus. Conversely, never spread one clan's holdings across the map. A clan with one fief in Vlandia, one in Sturgia, and one in the Aserai desert cannot defend any of them. Their parties spend all their time marching between holdings and never actually fight anyone.

This distribution strategy scales: as your kingdom conquers new territory, assign the border vassals to the new border and move the now-safe interior vassals to produce economy. The vassal who held the western border against Vlandia for five years earns the right to a peaceful interior town when Vlandia is conquered and the border moves further west.

Mechanics — Wave 2

Advanced systems for ruling a kingdom. These mechanics assume you are the ruler — the dynamics shift significantly when you are the one making decisions for an entire faction.

Kingdom Policies — Full Reference

This table covers every kingdom policy in Bannerlord. Unlike Wave 1's strategic overview, this is the complete mechanical reference. Each policy is explained with its exact effect, the council support required to enact or abolish it, the best era of a campaign to consider it, and a clear recommendation.

Policy	Effect	Support	Era	Recommendation
Council of Commons	Each notable in settlements you own grants +1 influence per day. Amplifies influence generation from every fief with notables — a town with 3 notables grants +3 influence daily.	Council vote — most vassals support	All eras	Enact and never abolish. The single best policy in the game for any character at any stage. Passive influence generation is always valuable, always compounds, and never has a downside.
Senate	Reduces influence cost of all council decisions by 20%. Army cohesion, policy proposals, fief claims, overruling votes — all cheaper.	Council vote — requires majority	Mid to late	Enact. The 20% discount pays for itself across every influence expense you make. If your kingdom was going to spend 1,000 influence on army cohesion in the next year, Senate saves you 200. Enact when your kingdom is large enough that influence expenses are significant.
Citizenship	+0.5 loyalty in all settlements, -5% tax income. The	Council vote	Early to mid	Conditional: enact if struggling with

	loyalty bonus helps prevent rebellion; the tax penalty reduces income from all your holdings by a small but compounding amount.			loyalty. If your settlements have loyalty problems — newly conquered towns, multicultural kingdoms, or border regions under constant pressure — the loyalty bonus is worth the tax penalty. If all your settlements are at 70+ loyalty, the tax penalty is wasted.
Imperial Towns	+10% tariff income from towns, -1 loyalty in all towns. Tariffs scale with trade volume — more caravans means more tariff income — but the loyalty penalty applies to every town every day.	Council vote	Late	Conditional: enact only if loyalty surplus exists. If every town in your kingdom has 60+ loyalty, the -1 penalty is absorbable and the 10% tariff bonus is pure profit. If any town is below 25 loyalty, this policy may tip it into rebellion. Do not enact with Citizenship — the two policies cancel each other's loyalty effects while costing you 5% tax income.
Feudal Inheritance	Fiefs pass to your clan when a vassal dies without heirs, but -1 influence per fief you own per day. The inheritance security is valuable — fiefs lost when vassal clans die out weaken the kingdom — but the	Council vote	Mid to late	Oppose as a small vassal, enact as a major landholder. The influence penalty is negligible when you own 5+ fiefs generating passive influence. When you own 1 fief, the penalty is significant. As

	influence penalty scales with your holdings.			ruler, the inheritance security protects your kingdom's territorial integrity over decades.
Trial by Jury	Reduces the relation penalty for overruling council decisions by roughly 50%. When you override the council to claim a fief or push through a policy, the relation damage with opposing clans is halved.	Council vote	Mid	Enact if you plan to rule by decree. If your strategy involves frequently overruling the council — claiming most sieged fiefs for yourself or your favorites — this policy saves you the accumulated relation damage. If you govern by consensus and rarely override, the benefit is wasted.
Noble Retinues	+25% party size for all clans, both yours and your vassals'. A clan that normally fields 120 troops now fields 150. Applies to your party, companion parties, and every vassal's party.	Council vote — universally popular with vassals	All eras	Enact and never abolish. More troops means stronger armies, better siege success, more influence from battles, and safer borders. The bonus applies to everyone, making it one of the few policies with zero political opposition. Every vassal wants this.
Royal Guard	Ruler clan gains +30 party size. All other clans suffer -5% tax income. Concentrates military power in the ruler's hands at the expense of vassal economy.	Council vote — vassals often oppose	As ruler only	Never enact as a vassal. Consider as a ruler with consolidation concerns. As a vassal, this directly taxes you to benefit someone else. As a ruler, it gives you a personal advantage in military power,

				which helps you overrule the council and enforce your will. The political cost is high — vassals hate this policy and opposing it builds your reputation with them.
Deeds of the King	Ruler gains +20% renown gain. All other clans lose –10% renown gain. Renown determines clan tier progression speed — the ruler climbs faster, everyone else climbs slower.	Council vote — vassals strongly oppose	As ruler only	Never enact as a vassal. As a ruler, only enact if you need to reach a specific clan tier quickly and are willing to slow your vassals' progression. The long-term cost is vassals who reach higher tiers slower, which means smaller parties and weaker armies. Usually not worth the political damage.
War Tax	+5% tax income from all settlements, –1 loyalty in all settlements during wartime. The income boost helps fund wartime expenses, but the loyalty penalty applies when loyalty is most vulnerable — when your settlements are newly conquered or under siege.	Council vote	Late	Conditional: enact when loyalty is high and funds are needed. The income is modest — enough to offset maybe half of your army cohesion costs during a major campaign — but the loyalty penalty can tip border towns into rebellion during a losing war. Safe only if all settlements have 50+ loyalty even with the penalty.

Bailiffs	+10% tax income from all settlements, –1 loyalty. A straightforward trade of loyalty for gold. The income boost is significant for large kingdoms with many high-prosperity settlements.	Council vote	Mid	Conditional: enact when you need immediate cash and can afford the loyalty dip. The revenue from four or five high-prosperity towns can fund a new army. But the loyalty penalty compounds with other negative-loyalty policies. If you also have Imperial Towns enacted, your towns are suffering –2 loyalty daily from policies alone.
Debasement of Currency	+15% tax income from all settlements, –2 loyalty. The most aggressive loyalty-for-gold trade in the game. The income boost is substantial — 15% of a 5,000-prosperity town's tax revenue is significant — but the loyalty penalty is severe.	Council vote — often controversial	Late, if ever	Rarely worth enacting. The loyalty penalty is large enough that towns without strong positive loyalty modifiers will slide into rebellion. Only safe in highly stable, long-established kingdoms where every town has a culture-matched governor, Fairgrounds, and 60+ loyalty baseline. For most kingdoms, this policy causes more problems than the gold solves.
Forgiveness of Debts	+2 loyalty in all settlements, –5% tax income. The mirror of Bailiffs — trade gold for loyalty. The loyalty boost is substantial and can rescue	Council vote	Early to mid	Enact if loyalty is a persistent problem. Useful in multicultural kingdoms, recently conquered territories, or during the

	settlements from the brink of rebellion.			consolidation phase after rapid expansion. The tax penalty is modest and the loyalty gain can be the difference between a stable kingdom and constant rebellion suppression.
Road Tolls	+5% tariff income, –0.5 loyalty. A small trade of loyalty for trade income. The loyalty penalty is minor — half a point — making this one of the safer economic policies to enact.	Council vote	Mid	Conditional: enact if you can spare the half-point of loyalty. The tariff boost is modest on its own but compounds with Imperial Towns and high trade volume. Safe enough to be almost always worth considering if your loyalty baseline can absorb the cost.
State Monopolies	+15% workshop income, +10% tariff income, –1 loyalty. Rewards towns with active workshops and high trade volume. The income boost is substantial but only applies to settlements where these economic activities are already happening.	Council vote	Late	Enact in mature kingdoms with developed economies. If your kingdom has multiple towns with high-prosperity workshops and active trade routes, the income boost is significant. If your kingdom is still building its first few workshops, the benefit is minimal and the loyalty penalty is wasted.
Land Tax	+5% tax income from villages, –2% settlement prosperity growth.	Council vote	Mid to late	Generally oppose. The village tax income boost is modest and the

	Shifts income from long-term prosperity growth to immediate tax revenue. Village tax income is a small portion of total kingdom revenue — this policy affects a narrow slice of the economy.			prosperity growth penalty on settlements slows the long-term development of every fief. Prosperity compounds — a 2% slower growth rate over a decade of game time means your towns never reach the prosperity levels that generate major income.
Sacred Majesty	Ruler gains +10% influence generation. All other clans lose -5% influence generation. Funnels the kingdom's political currency to the ruler.	Council vote — vassals strongly oppose	As ruler only	Never enact as a vassal. As a ruler, only enact if you have strong influence needs and can afford the vassal resentment. The influence shift is not enormous — 10% of a ruler's already-high influence generation is noticeable but not game-changing. The vassal penalty creates a permanent negative modifier on your relationship with every clan.
Peerage	+1 influence per day for every clan in the kingdom, including yours. A flat influence bonus that benefits everyone equally — the rare policy with no losers.	Council vote — universally popular	All eras	Enact immediately and never abolish. Free influence for everyone, no penalties, no tradeoffs. This is the policy you propose when you want to build political capital —

				every clan that votes yes gains relation with you, and the policy itself benefits everyone equally.
Hunting Rights	Villages produce +2 food per day. A flat increase to food production across your kingdom, which improves settlement food security and reduces vulnerability to siege-induced starvation.	Council vote	Early to mid	Enact and keep. More food means settlements take longer to starve during sieges, prosperity grows faster when food is abundant, and villages are less likely to be stripped bare by passing armies. A quiet policy with consistent, compounding benefits. No downside.
Grazing Rights	Villages produce +2 horses per day and +1 herd animal. Increases the availability of mounts for cavalry recruitment and herd animals for carrying capacity.	Council vote	Mid	Conditional: enact if your kingdom's military relies on cavalry. Khuzait and Vlandian kingdoms benefit significantly from faster cavalry replenishment. Sturgian and Battanian kingdoms benefit less. The horse production bonus shortens the time between cavalry losses in war and cavalry replacements being available for recruitment.
Serfdom	+10% food from villages, -1 loyalty in villages. Increases food	Council vote	Late	Rarely worth enacting. The food bonus is moderate and the loyalty

	production at the cost of village stability. Village loyalty feeds into town loyalty indirectly through the economy chain — unhappy villages produce less for their attached towns.			penalty on villages degrades the village-to-town production pipeline. A town fed by unhappy villages receives fewer goods, earns less tariff income, and grows prosperity slower. The food you gain from Serfdom is partially offset by the economic damage the loyalty penalty causes.
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Policy Selection Strategy

Choose policies that address your kingdom's most pressing problem. If your kingdom is struggling with loyalty, enact Forgiveness of Debts and Citizenship before touching economic policies that penalize loyalty. If your kingdom is broke, enact Bailiffs and Road Tolls before touching Debasement of Currency. If your kingdom is politically unstable, enact Peerage and Trial by Jury to stabilize vassal relations.

The most dangerous trap is enacting too many negative-loyalty policies simultaneously. A town suffering -1 Loyalty from Imperial Towns, -1 from Bailiffs, and -2 from Debasement of Currency is losing 4 loyalty per day from policies alone. A culture-mismatched governor and the recent-ownership penalty push the total above -7. No amount of Fairgrounds and festival funding can outpace that. The maximum safe number of negative-loyalty policies is two for a mature kingdom, one for a growing kingdom, zero for a newly founded one.

Policies also have political costs beyond their stated effects. Every time a policy vote occurs, the clans vote based on their perceived self-interest. Supporting a policy that benefits you at vassal expense (Royal Guard, Sacred Majesty, Deeds of the King) costs relation with every clan that votes against it. Supporting a universally popular policy (Peerage, Noble Retinues, Council of Commons) builds relation with the majority. Use the political dimension of policy votes to manage vassal relations, not just to optimize kingdom stats.

Vassal Management in Detail

Fief Distribution Algorithm

When a kingdom captures a fief, the game determines who receives it through a weighted algorithm. Understanding this algorithm lets you predict outcomes and spend influence strategically rather than reactively.

The algorithm's primary factor is **participation score** — a composite measure of which clan contributed most to the siege. Troops committed to the siege camp, siege engines constructed, and time spent in the siege camp all contribute. A clan that commits 400 troops, builds two trebuchets, and spends the full two weeks of the siege in the camp will have a dramatically higher participation score than a clan that arrives on day twelve with 50 troops. If you want a specific fief for yourself, lead the siege personally and commit your best troops for the full duration.

The secondary factor is **clan tier**. Higher-tier clans receive priority in fief distribution, reflecting their greater political weight in the kingdom. A Clan Tier 5 vassal with zero fiefs will outbid a Clan Tier 2 vassal with the same participation score. Clan tier is a long-term investment — everything you do to increase your renown increases your claim priority in future fief votes.

The tertiary factors are **existing holdings**, **relation with the ruler**, and **culture match**. Clans with fewer fiefs receive priority over clans with many. Clans with high relation to the ruler receive priority — the ruler’s personal feelings influence the weight of their vote. Clans whose culture matches the fief’s culture receive priority, reflecting the game’s assumption that culturally compatible rulers govern more effectively.

As ruler, you can override the algorithm by spending influence on a specific candidate. The more influence you spend, the more likely the council accepts your choice. A 50-influence bid signals a mild preference. A 150-influence bid signals that this fief will go to your chosen candidate regardless of the algorithm. Spend influence when the algorithm’s choice would create a strategic problem — giving a key border castle to a Clan Tier 2 vassal with 30 troops, for example — and let the algorithm decide when the outcome does not materially affect your kingdom.

Preventing Defection

Detailed loyalty mechanics govern whether a vassal clan remains in your kingdom or leaves. The three thresholds are absolute: relation above +50 is the safe zone where defection is essentially impossible; relation between -20 and +50 is the neutral zone where conditions determine defection risk; relation below -20 is the danger zone where defection is imminent.

Fief count interacts with relation thresholds. A vassal at -15 relation with three fiefs will not defect — their investment outweighs their discontent. A vassal at +10 relation with zero fiefs is a defection risk — no investment to lose, only discontent to act on. Fief grants are the emergency brake on a vassal’s defection timer. When the clan screen shows a vassal as “restless” or “considering leaving,” granting them any fief — even a minor castle — resets the defection timer and buys you several months.

Shared enemies provide the passive relation maintenance. Fight alongside your vassals. When the kingdom is at war, be at the front with the army that includes your discontent vassals. Each battle fought together against the same enemy generates a small relation boost that accumulates over a campaign. A vassal who sees you at every major battle will not defect, even if their fief count is low. A vassal who has not seen their king on a battlefield in years will defect even with adequate fiefs.

Marriage ties are the permanent solution. Marry a family member into a vassal’s clan, and that clan gains a permanent +10 to +20 relation buff with your clan that does not decay. This buff applies to every member of their clan — the clan leader, their party leaders, their governors. A marriage tie is expensive in political capital and requires available family members, but it transforms a temporary fix into a permanent solution. The vassal whose son married your daughter will never defect unless conditions become catastrophic.

Check the clan screen regularly — at minimum every two in-game weeks during peacetime and every few days during wartime. The clan screen shows each vassal’s current relation, fief count, and any status effects that indicate defection risk. A vassal whose status changes from “content” to “considering their options” has approximately a month before they act. You have time to fix the problem if you notice it early. You have no time if you notice it when the notification says “Clan dey Meroc has left the kingdom.”

Removing Problem Vassals

Sometimes a vassal is more trouble than they are worth — a clan that consistently votes against your policies, contributes minimal troops to campaigns, and hoards fiefs without developing them. Removing a vassal is possible but expensive.

Vote to exile is the direct method. Propose expulsion of the clan through the kingdom council. Costs substantial influence and requires majority council support, which means you need enough relation with other vassals that they will vote with you against the target clan. The exiled clan takes their fiefs with them — those fiefs become independent or join the exiled clan's new kingdom. This is the cleanest method of removal but also the most politically expensive. Only use it when the vassal's fiefs are strategically insignificant (a single minor castle) or when you have enough influence and council support to absorb the cost.

Provoke rebellion is the indirect method. Identify a fief owned by the problem vassal that has low loyalty. Withdraw the garrison — the security penalty drops loyalty to zero. Stop festival funding. Let the town rebel. The rebels capture the town, removing it from the vassal's ownership, and you reconquer it from the rebel faction. The reconquered fief enters the normal distribution cycle and can be assigned to a different vassal. This method is slow — weeks of loyalty decay followed by a rebellion followed by a siege — but costs no influence and damages no relations. It is the surgical removal tool for powerful vassals with strategically valuable fiefs.

Let enemies capture them is the passive method. March your armies away from the problem vassal's territory. When an enemy army invades and captures the vassal's fiefs, those fiefs are now enemy holdings — and when you reconquer them, they are assigned through the normal fief distribution algorithm to any vassal you choose. The vassal may be captured during the invasion. Decline to ransom them. A vassal in an enemy dungeon cannot vote on the council, cannot oppose your policies, and earns zero influence. This method is passive and slow, but it costs nothing and carries zero political risk — you did not betray the vassal, the enemy captured them.

Danger: Exiled vassals join enemy kingdoms and bring three things with them: grievances against you (lowering your reputation with their new kingdom and making future diplomacy harder), border knowledge (they know exactly which castles are under-garrisoned and where your armies are positioned), and contacts (they have existing relations with your other vassals and may encourage additional defections). Exiling a vassal whose sister is married to your most loyal vassal may trigger a chain reaction of defections. Consider the clan web before wielding the axe.

Economy at Scale

Taxation Optimization

Taxation at kingdom scale is the composite result of settlement prosperity, tax rate multipliers from policies, and tariff income from trade. Understanding how these pieces interact lets you maximize kingdom revenue without crippling growth.

Prosperity is the base multiplier for all tax income. A town with 5,000 prosperity generates roughly five times the tax revenue of a town with 1,000 prosperity. Every investment you make that increases prosperity — buildings, governor assignment, food security, cultural stability — pays dividends in tax income that compound over years. A Fairgrounds that costs 3,000 denars to build and increases loyalty by +1 will, through faster construction and higher prosperity, generate far more than 3,000 denars in additional tax revenue over its lifetime.

Tax rate is the policy multiplier applied to prosperity-based income. Each percentage point of tax rate increase from policies — Bailiffs (+10%), Debasement of Currency (+15%), War Tax (+5%) — multiplies the base tax revenue of every settlement in your kingdom. This sounds appealing until you factor in the loyalty penalties these same policies impose. A -2 loyalty penalty from Debasement of Currency reduces construction speed by roughly 10% and slows prosperity growth. The 15% tax bonus is partially consumed by the prosperity it prevents from ever being earned. At kingdom scale, the math favors loyalty over tax rate — a prosperous, loyal town generates sustainable, growing income. A taxed, unhappy town generates static, diminishing income.

Tariff income is the third revenue stream. Tariffs are collected when caravans and villagers trade at your towns' markets. Higher trade volume means higher tariff income. Policies that boost tariffs (Imperial Towns +10%, Road Tolls +5%) multiply this stream. Tariff income is independent of prosperity in the short term — a town with low prosperity can still have high trade volume if it sits on a major trade route between rich kingdoms. The trade routes are the real asset. A town on the route between Vlandian silver mines and Aserai silk markets generates tariff income regardless of its own prosperity, because the caravans passing through pay tariffs at every stop.

The optimal tax strategy for a mature kingdom is: maximum loyalty policies (Forgiveness of Debts, Citizenship, Hunting Rights), moderate tax rate (Bailiffs only, skip Debasement of Currency), and maximize trade volume (Road Tolls, State Monopolies, protect trade routes from bandits). This produces growing, sustainable income rather than maximum immediate income that strangles future growth.

Workshop Empire Management

Workshop management at kingdom scale requires allocating the limited workshop cap across your holdings for maximum passive income.

The base cap is one workshop per clan, plus one additional workshop for each clan tier above Tier 2, to a maximum of five workshops at Clan Tier 6. This cap applies per clan, not per kingdom — your vassals also own workshops, and their workshop income funds their parties and garrison wages. You do not control vassal workshops directly, but policies like State Monopolies (+15% workshop income) benefit every workshop in the kingdom, including your vassals'.

Optimal workshop placement follows a simple rule: place workshops in towns you own whenever possible, because owning the town eliminates the rent cost. A workshop in a town you do not own pays a percentage of its profits to the town's owner. A workshop in your own town pays zero rent — 100% of profits flow to your treasury. This makes workshop placement a strategic decision alongside fief distribution. When you are determining which towns to keep for yourself versus grant to vassals, factor in which towns have the best workshop opportunities.

Synergy effects compound workshop income. A Smithy in a town you own that is fed by two iron-producing villages produces cheap iron, which the Smithy converts into tools, which your caravan trades to other towns, which generates tariff income when the caravan passes through your toll-station towns. The village-to-workshop-to-caravan-to-tariff chain turns a single 13,000-denar workshop investment into four simultaneous income streams. Identifying and exploiting these synergy chains is the difference between a workshop that earns 200 denars per day and a workshop that earns 500 denars per day while simultaneously boosting your caravans and tariffs.

Tip: A smithy in a town with iron villages plus a caravan trading weapons creates a compound income loop. The smithy profits from cheap raw iron. The caravan buys the smithy's weapons at wholesale prices and sells them at retail to towns without smithies. The tariff income from the caravan passing through your other towns adds a third revenue stream. One strategic workshop choice generates income across three separate systems.

War Profiteering

War is expensive, but war is also profitable if you approach it as an economic activity rather than just a military one. The three revenue streams of war are captured gear, ransomed lords, and tribute payments.

Post-battle loot scales with enemy troop quality. Defeating a 500-man army of Tier 4 and Tier 5 troops produces dramatically more valuable loot than defeating 500 Tier 1 recruits. The gear you capture — armor, weapons, horses — sells for thousands of denars per major battle. A campaign against a well-equipped faction like Vlandia (heavy cavalry with expensive armor and horses) produces significantly

more loot than a campaign against a poorly equipped faction. Choose your wars partly based on the quality of the loot you will recover — a war against Vlandia costs more in troop losses but pays more in captured equipment, and the net may be positive on both territory and gold.

Ransoming lords provides lump-sum income for each captured enemy noble. Higher-tier clan leaders ransom for more gold — a faction leader or high-tier clan patriarch may ransom for 10,000 to 30,000 denars. The ransom value decreases if the same lord has been ransomed repeatedly — the game tracks ransom fatigue and reduces the payout each time. For maximum per-lord income, capture lords in major battles, ransom them immediately, and pray they do not get captured again for a while. For maximum political damage, keep captured lords in your dungeons instead — a lord in your dungeon cannot lead armies, and their clan loses influence every day they are imprisoned. The gold versus political-damage choice is a strategic decision, not just a financial one.

Tribute payments are the most profitable outcome of a successful war. Defeated kingdoms pay daily tribute to the victor for the duration of the peace treaty, with the amount scaling based on the power disparity at the time of the peace deal. Crush a kingdom's armies, capture half their fiefs, and the peace treaty may demand 1,000 to 3,000 denars per day in tribute for several months. This is kingdom-scale passive income — gold that arrives daily without any further action on your part.

The tribute exploitation loop works as follows. Defeat a faction decisively. Demand maximum tribute in the peace treaty — the AI will accept tribute demands that reflect their current military weakness. Let the defeated faction recover for the peace treaty duration — they rebuild armies, restock garrisons, and remember nothing. When the treaty expires, declare war again while they are still weaker than you but have recovered enough to have assets worth taking. Defeat them again. Demand more tribute. Repeat until the faction is economically exhausted and can be conquered entirely. Each cycle takes a year or more, but each cycle produces territory, loot, ransoms, and tribute payments that fund the next war.

Rebellion Suppression

Loyalty Mechanics

Settlement loyalty is a number from 0 to 100, and it is the single most important stat for any fief you control. Every mechanic that affects a settlement — construction speed, prosperity growth, tax generation, rebellion risk — is downstream of loyalty. A settlement at 100 loyalty builds projects in half the time of a settlement at 50. A settlement at 15 loyalty is on the verge of open revolt.

The loyalty formula has six components. **Culture match** grants +1 per matching source — owner culture, governor culture — to a maximum of +2 from culture match alone. This is the most reliable positive modifier and the first thing you should fix in any settlement with loyalty problems. **Security** provides a bonus scaling from the garrison's troop count relative to the settlement's population — a full garrison of 200 troops in a 5,000-population town grants roughly +1 to +2 loyalty. Security is expensive in garrison wages but reliable — troops do not get unhappy. **Governor skills** — Charm directly boosts loyalty by a small amount per skill point (roughly +1 per 50 Charm). **Policies** apply kingdom-wide loyalty modifiers. **Recent ownership** is a temporary -3 penalty that decays over approximately 30 days after the settlement changes hands. **Starvation** applies a sharp penalty when the settlement has zero food — roughly -1 loyalty per day with no upper bound, guaranteed to trigger rebellion within three to four weeks if unresolved.

The starvation penalty is the fastest route to rebellion. A town under siege that runs out of food loses loyalty at catastrophic speed. Even after the siege is lifted, the town's food stores are empty and will take days to replenish from incoming village caravans, during which the loyalty penalty continues to apply. After a siege, immediately fund festivals and transfer food from your party to the town — the loyalty rescue is more urgent than the tax revenue you lose during the festival period.

Militia presence protects against rebellion but does not affect the loyalty stat. Militia troops are civilians who take up arms when the settlement is attacked — they defend the settlement during sieges but do

not provide the security loyalty bonus that garrison troops provide. A town with a large militia and no garrison will rebel based on its loyalty score alone, and the militia will fight against you during the rebellion.

Suppressing Rebellion

When a settlement's loyalty drops into the danger zone — approximately 15 to 25 — you have a limited window to prevent rebellion. The suppression strategy has four elements.

Garrison threshold: the garrison must be large enough that the security loyalty bonus keeps the settlement above the rebellion threshold. The formula is roughly: garrison troop count divided by settlement population, multiplied by a constant. For a 5,000-population town, a garrison of 150 to 200 troops provides a security bonus of +1 to +2 loyalty. Increase the garrison if loyalty continues to fall.

Governor assignment is the most impactful single action. A governor with high Charm (150+) and matching culture provides +2 to +3 net loyalty — enough to stabilize most settlements on its own. If your current governor is not culture-matched, fire them and assign one who is, even if the culture-matched governor has lower overall skills. The loyalty bonus from culture match is worth more than the prosperity bonus from a high-Steward governor in a crisis.

Festival funding converts denars into temporary loyalty boosts. Fund the Festival project from the settlement management screen — it costs gold per day and increases loyalty while active. The cost is steep (hundreds of denars per day depending on settlement size and prosperity), but it can buy you the thirty days needed for the recent-ownership penalty to decay or for the Fairgrounds building project to complete. Festival funding is an emergency measure, not a permanent solution — the gold cost is unsustainable long-term.

Building priority in a loyalty crisis shifts. The building queue should be: Fairgrounds first (+1 loyalty, accelerates everything that follows), Granary second (prevents the starvation loyalty penalty during the next siege), and nothing else until loyalty is above 40. Building income-generating structures in a settlement that is about to rebel is worse than wasted — it is actively harmful, because you are investing resources in a settlement you are about to lose.

Exploiting Enemy Rebellion

Rebellions in enemy kingdoms are strategic opportunities. When an enemy town rebels against its owner, it becomes an independent minor faction with no allies, no parent kingdom, and no diplomatic relationships. You can attack and capture it without declaring war on its parent kingdom.

Supporting enemy rebels is possible through funding. Some mods add mechanics for this; in vanilla, rebellions occur naturally when enemy loyalty management fails. Monitor the diplomacy screen for notifications of rebellions in enemy kingdoms. A town that rebels in a faction you are at war with is a gift — capture it without fighting the parent kingdom's armies, without the parent kingdom's allies joining the war, and without spending influence on a war declaration.

Capturing secessionist towns follows the standard siege mechanics but with the critical advantage that no allies will come to the rebel faction's defense. The rebel army is typically the size of the former garrison plus militia — a challenging but manageable target for a mid-sized kingdom army. Once captured, the settlement follows the standard recent-ownership penalty of -3 loyalty for thirty days, so have a culture-matched governor and festival funding ready.

The parent kingdom may attempt to reconquer the town later. If you are at war with them, this is a standard military engagement. If you are at peace with them, they may declare war specifically to reclaim the town — the AI values lost territory highly in war declaration calculations. However, if you maintain a strong garrison and the loyalty penalty decays, the town becomes your property in the eyes of the game's ownership mechanics, and the parent kingdom's claim weakens over time. A town you

have held for six months with 60+ loyalty and a culture-matched governor is your town — the parent kingdom has accepted this.

Cultural Integration

Culture Conversion

Settlement culture changes over time through passive and active mechanics. In vanilla Bannerlord, culture conversion is slow — approximately 1% to 2% of the settlement's population converts per in-game year if the governor's culture matches the owner's culture. A settlement with a matching-owner-culture governor will slowly shift toward the owning kingdom's culture over decades. This is too slow to be strategically relevant for most campaigns, but it provides a long-term loyalty benefit in very long games.

Policy acceleration is available through certain policies and modded mechanics. Some overhaul mods in Wave 2 may add active culture conversion options — check individual mod documentation for conversion rates, costs, and prerequisites. Active conversion is typically expensive in gold or influence and applies over months rather than decades.

The practical takeaway is that culture conversion is a multi-generational process in vanilla. Do not rely on conversion to solve short-term loyalty problems. The recent-ownership penalty will have decayed to zero long before any meaningful culture shift has occurred. Build your loyalty strategy around culture-matched governors and strong garrisons, not around waiting for the settlement to culturally assimilate.

Multicultural Kingdoms

Managing loyalty penalties across a multicultural kingdom is the primary challenge of mid-to-late game kingdom management. Every fief whose culture does not match its governor suffers -1 loyalty per day. Every fief whose culture does not match its owner suffers an additional -1.

The solution is distributing culture-matching vassals or governors to every fief. Recruit vassals from every conquered culture — Imperial lords to govern Imperial towns, Battanian clans to hold Battanian territory, Sturgian families to manage Sturgian borders. This requires making your kingdom diplomatically attractive to lords from all factions, which means high general reputation, lucrative fief offers, and victorious wars that prove your kingdom's staying power.

A kingdom that is militarily weak but culturally diverse will lose vassals to cultural tension. A kingdom that is militarily dominant will attract vassals from every faction regardless of culture — lords join winners. The path to a stable multicultural kingdom is through military success, not cultural sensitivity. Win enough wars, and the Sturgian lords will decide that being Sturgian matters less than being on the winning side.

Cultural Benefits

Settlement culture provides passive bonuses that compound over campaigns but will not determine the outcome of wars by themselves.

Native recruitment: troops recruited in territory that matches their native culture are available at higher tiers. An Imperial village in Imperial-culture territory may allow recruiting Imperial Legionaries directly, while an Imperial village in Battanian-culture territory may only offer recruits up to Tier 3. This accelerates army rebuilding in culturally homogenous regions and slows it in multicultural border zones.

Morale effects: troops fighting for a kingdom whose culture matches their own gain a small morale bonus. The effect is modest — roughly +2 to +5 morale — and primarily noticeable in long battles where morale becomes the decisive factor. A mixed-culture army will not noticeably underperform versus a monoculture army of equal tier and composition. Cultural morale bonuses are flavor, not a strategic consideration for army composition.

Prosperity growth: towns and villages whose owner's culture matches their own culture gain prosperity slightly faster — roughly 5% to 10% faster growth. Over a decade, this produces noticeably larger towns, but the effect is gradual and secondary to the prosperity effects of food security, loyalty, and building upgrades. A culturally mismatched town with Fairgrounds, a Granary, and a skilled governor will outgrow a culturally matched town with no infrastructure.

Mod List — Wave 2

Wave 2 introduces **Heavy overhaul** mods — mods that fundamentally change or replace core systems. This is the most transformative and highest-risk wave. Every previous category (UI/QoL, Graphics, Light mechanic, Content addition) is also present, inherited from Waves 0 and 1.

Danger: Wave 2 load order is the most fragile. A single misplaced mod can cause cascading conflicts. Verify with Auto-Sort, then manually adjust to match the load order section. When adding real mods, test the full load order before starting a campaign.

=== Heavy overhaul Mod Placeholder

A Heavy overhaul mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Rebalanced prices, supply/demand rework across all regions
- Workshop profitability overhaul — workshops are long-term investments, not quick money
- Trade skill rebalanced — 300 Trade is genuinely game-changing rather than a grind

Requirements: Must make economy harder without making it unfun. Must integrate with any diplomatic or kingdom overhaul mods.

=== Heavy overhaul Mod Placeholder

A Heavy overhaul mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Vassal management rework — more nuanced loyalty, more meaningful councils
- Policy system expanded — more policies, more consequences, harder to change
- Rebellion mechanics deepened — unrest visible before it triggers, more player agency
- Diplomacy system rebuilt — alliances, non-aggression pacts, tribute, hostages

Requirements: Must not make kingdom stability trivial or impossible. Must allow player agency in all decisions. Must integrate with other Wave 2 overhaul mods.

=== Heavy overhaul Mod Placeholder

A Heavy overhaul mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Armor formula rework — armor matters more, naked berserkers are no longer viable
- Weapon balance pass — all weapon types have a role, no 'never-use' categories
- New damage types and injury system — wounds have consequences beyond the battle

Requirements: Must increase realism without breaking faction balance. Sturgians should still win shield walls. Khuzait should still win open-field cavalry fights.

=== Heavy overhaul Mod Placeholder

A Heavy overhaul mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Recruitment reworked — culture, region, and relation all affect who you can recruit
- Troop trees expanded and rebalanced — every faction has a viable late-game composition
- Noble vs common troop distinction meaningful — noble troops are special, not just +1 tier

Requirements: Must preserve faction identity. Battanians remain best archers. Vlandians remain best shock cavalry. No faction should become the answer to every question.

=== Heavy overhaul Mod Placeholder

A Heavy overhaul mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- New factions and map changes — expanded world with more political actors
- Dynamic world events — famines, plagues, great tournaments, religious schisms
- Cultural mechanics deepened — culture conversion, cultural tensions, cultural alliances

Requirements: Must be compatible with BL 1.4.7 map data. Must integrate with other Wave 2 overhaul mods. Must not introduce game-breaking event chains.

=== Content addition Mod Placeholder

A Content addition mod will go here.

Examples of what this slot should contain:

- Legendary weapons and armor for late game — rewards for the greatest achievements
- Unique items from specific quests, bosses, or events — not buyable, only earnable
- Cosmetic variations — look like a king when you become one

Requirements: Must not add pre-endgame power creep. Legendary items should require legendary achievements. A fresh character should not be able to acquire them.

Load Order — Wave 2

The correct load order for all Wave 2 mods, listed from top to bottom. This includes mods inherited from Waves 0 and 1 plus the new Wave 2 entries.

Warning: The load order is a suggested template based on placeholder mods. When real mods are added, update this table with actual mod names and verified positions.

Load Order Rules (Wave 2)

1. **UI/QoL and Graphics:** Inherited from Waves 0 and 1 — load first
2. **Content addition:** Inherited from Wave 1 + new Wave 2 content — load after graphics
3. **Light mechanic:** Inherited from Wave 1 — load after content
4. **Heavy overhaul:** New in Wave 2 — load last, ordered by system dependency:
 1. Economy (other systems depend on prices and trade)
 2. World & Faction (map and faction changes define the playing field)
 3. Combat & Damage (combat math applies on top of faction balance)

4. Troop & Recruitment (troops depend on faction definitions)
5. Kingdom Management (highest-level system — depends on everything below)

Danger: Wave 2 load order is the most fragile. A single misplaced mod can cause cascading conflicts. Test the full load order before starting a campaign. When in doubt, load the mod that changes the FEWER systems first, and the mod that changes the MOST systems last.